# How To DEFEAT The Smith-Morra Gambit: 6...a6



IM Timothy Taylor

# HOW TO DEFEAT THE SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT: 6... a6!

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This book is for my beloved daughters, Vanessa and Aileen.

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Other books by Timothy Taylor

Chess/Nonfiction
THE RUBINSTEIN VARIATION OF THE NIMZO-INDIAN DEFENSE
NEW YORK 1985: THE MANHATTAN CHESS CLUB INTERNATIONAL

Novels
ELAINE THE FAIR
AMANDA

"Any one who does not fear death himself can inflict it."
Niccolo Machiavelli

# INTRODUCTION

The player who uses the Sicilian, as I do, as his main defense to 1.e4 must of necessity confront the Smith-Morra Gambit. It is important to take this gambit seriously: consider the well known case of Grandmaster and World Championship Candidate Svetozar Gligoric, who gave up a Gambit Accepted draw to the virtually unknown Pokojowczyk in 1971 (see the notes to Game 2).

Not wishing to share Gligoric's grief, I have seriously studied the Black counters to the Gambit for twenty years. I believe my results speak for themselves: six wins, no draws, no losses. I defeated such opponents as current US Champion Patrick Wolff (though the game was played long before he won that title), IM Jim Rizzitano, and various amateur gambit specialists. Also, in a game specially played for this book, I defeated my Zarkov chess computer. If I learned one thing from these games, it is that *Black must attack.* Passive play may allow White to work up adequate pressure for the pawn. Black must strive to take over the initiative at the earliest possible point.

Part I of this book presents three introductory games which explain how Black should *not* play. This section includes the famous Fischer - Korchnoi game from Buenos Aires 1960, which has been incorrectly analyzed for 33 years. In this book I point out the errors of both players and analysts, and try to give the first objective look at this important game.

Then we go to the system that I have refined over the years based on the move order 1.e4 c5 2.d4 cd 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 a6! This system was made viable by GM Larry Evans'

continuation 7.0-0 Nf6 8.Bg5 e6 9.Qe2 h6! (Game 4) which he used to defeat the Gambit's greatest champion, Ken Smith, at San Antonio 1972. Smith lost after 10.Bh4; my opponents have tried his later recommendation 10.Bf4 (Game 6) and also 10.Be3 (Game 5) without any better success. These three games make up Part II.

These losses have induced White players to seek improvements on move 8, such as Qe2, Bf4, a3, and h3. The failure of these systems is demonstrated in Part III, Games 7-11.

Can we conclude then that the Gambit is refuted? No, for just as pawn-snatchers will always happily pile up their material, so gambiteers will always seek new avenues of attack. The twelfth and last game of the book (Part IV) features a new plan for White, that has to my knowledge been played in only a single published game. In the notes to that game I also point out a different untested idea for White (it's better to prepare for these blows at home than to be surprised by them over the board!). The results are not in on these new ideas yet, though I believe Black should maintain the edge.

One final note for the reader: this book is organized on the same principle as my earlier opening book on the Rubinstein Nimzo-Indian. My own games are featured because I will not recommend any line that I am not willing to play. Complete games are given, since opening structures often persist all the way to the endgame. Errors in other opening books are noted; I've always tried to ignore "received wisdom" and look at positions with an unprejudiced eye.

Those who carefully study this book, especially noting the transpositional possibilities - *and who keep an aggressive outlook* - will be well-prepared to defeat the Smith-Morra Gambit.



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# PART I

## HOW BLACK SHOULD *NOT* PLAY

It is a curious statistic that, in the 55 *Chess Informants* so far published, the Smith-Morra Gambit has scored an exactly even score: six wins, six losses, and two draws. This is an amazingly good score for a rather doubtful gambit, but these results can be primarily ascribed to one cause: the Black players didn't know what they were doing! I have already mentioned Gligoric's failure to defeat Pokojowczyk, but even worse was to follow. In a *correspondence* game in 1990, Belenko - Ermakov (Inf. 50/170 - Game 1 in this book) Black played a defense that has been discredited for almost 40 years - so naturally he was soundly thrashed! Why would a correspondence player, with access to all sorts of chess publications, play a dubious defense when the best line, with 5... d6 and 6... a6, has been known since Smith - Evans, San Antonio 1972?

The answer is, I'm afraid, that dreadful new disease: Chess Informant dependency. The vitally important Smith - Evans game was never published in the Informant. The game should have been cited for best opening novelty - but it wasn't even listed. For that matter, this crucial game doesn't get so much as a footnote in ECO! Knowing this, it's hardly surprising that my own important theoretical wins against Wolff and Rizzitano received an equal lack of attention.

So to a certain extent the gambit has received a free ride through lack of publication of Black's best moves. Also, the main opening books on the gambit so far published have taken the White side: SICILIAN: SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT ACCEPTED (Chess Digest 1982) by Ken Smith; THE MORRA-SMITH GAMBIT (Batsford 1981) by Janos Flesch; and DEVELOPMENTS IN THE



SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT (Quadrant 1990) by Neil Carr. All these books take a very optimistic point of view about White's chances - and every one of them underestimates the 6... a6 line.

I will refer to the above books throughout the text: when I quote Smith, Flesch, or Carr, that means the quote is taken from one of those particular books. Quotes from any other sources will be identified as they occur. A full list of the bibliography used in my research will be appended at the end of this book.

On that note, let's look at a Smith-Morra Gambit that works like a charm - White gets a crushing attack by move 13!

Always remember, dear reader, that if you do *not* study this opening, that might someday be you in Ermakov's shoes!

### GAME 1: BLACK TRIES A KINGSIDE FIANCHETTO

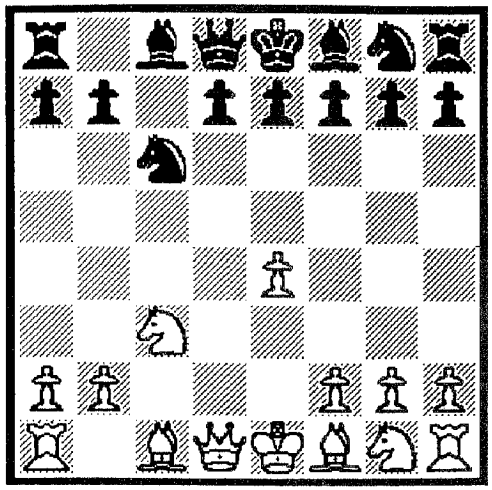
Correspondence 1990

| Belenko | Ermakov |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |

"The best way to refute a gambit is to accept it," as Larry Evans comments in the notes to Smith - Evans, San Antonio 1972 (Game 4 in this book).

| | |
|---|---|
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |

( See the diagram on the next page)



The diagram shows the basic opening position of the Smith-Morra: White has sacrificed a pawn for open lines. Though White has no lead in development now, he will soon, for all the White pieces can come out easily (both center pawns out of the way) while Black will have to move his pawns and then develop.

From Black's point of view, his unmoved center pawns must be viewed as an asset rather than a handicap: his center pawn majority should go a long way toward neutralizing White's attacking chances. Following Steinitz, Black must above all counter White's central play; wing demonstrations are harmless when the center is well defended.

Black ignores these principles in this game, which makes it valuable as a *drastic* object lesson.

**5. Nf3 g6?!**

Black starts down the wrong path. This move does nothing to counter White's central superiority. Instead, a center pawn should be moved. 5... e6 (Game 2) is reasonable and playable; 5... d6, taking a central square while blockading White's e pawn, is best.

**6. Bc4 Bg7**



If Black tries to restrain White's center pawn now with 6... d6, he runs into a tactical blow that is typical of White's "all lines are open" attacking setup: 7.Bg5 Bg7 8.Qb3 and Black can't protect f7.

**7. e5!**

Quieter moves lead nowhere. Take Nakhlik - Holmov, USSR 1957 for example: 7.0-0?! d6 8.Bf4 (8.Qb3 can now be met by 8... Na5!, e.g. 9.Bf7+? Kf8 10.Qd5 Nf6 -+; in the variation given to move 6, this line wouldn't work for Black because of Bf6 at the end) 8... Nf6 9.Qe2 O-O 10.Rd1 Bg4. Here Black stands better, having consolidated his position while maintaining his extra pawn.

The text move, 7.e5, is clearly best: White dominates the center and destroys the normal development of Black's Kingside (no Nf6). The fact that this move sacrifices a second pawn will hardly deter any true gambiteer.

The only funny thing about 7.e5 is that Belenko, in his Informant annotations, affixes a big N for novelty to it! In fact, as the subsequent notes show, this move has been played several times previously going back to 1954! However none of those games were published in the Chess Informants. Does that mean they don't exist?

**7... Qa5**

The immediate gift acceptance runs into 7... Ne5 8.Ne5 Be5 9.Bf7+!. Conroy - Rathbone, England 1975, continued with 9... Kf7 10.Qd5+ e6 (10... Kf6? 11.Ne4+ Kf5 12.g4+ with a winning attack) 11.Qe5 Qf6 12.Qc7 Ne7 13.O-O Nc6 14.Ne4 Qe5 15.Nd6+ Ke7 16.Rd1 Rd8 and now 17.h4! (Flesch) gives White a winning dark square attack.

If Black declines the second pawn his game is still not easy, e.g. 7... d6 8.Qb3 e6 9.Bg5 with an attack, or 7... Nh6 8.Bf4 and

White maintains the "bone in the throat" at e5, while the Black pieces are cramped at the edges of the board.

**8. O-O** **Ne5**

**9. Ne5** **Be5**

**10. Re1**

Also strong is 10.Nd5 Nf6 (10... e6 11.Re1 f6 12.Bb3 Kf7 13.Re5! with a powerful attack, Sokolov - Pete, Yugoslavia 1954 - remember that date the next time you see N in the Informants!) 11.Re1 d6 12.Bb5+! Kd8 (The blocks fail: 12... Bd7 13.Re5!, or 12... Nd7 13.f4, so Black is forced to leave his King in the center) 13.Re5! Qb5 14.Bf4 again with a very strong attack, Flesch - Koszorus, Hungary 1979.

**10...** **Bc3?**

Much too greedy - and even worse, Black once again ignores the center. Best is 10... d6, to meet 11.Nd5 with Be6 (but not 11... Nf6 12.Bb5+, transposing to the note above) when Black has defensive chances. After 10... d6 White's best is 11.Qf3, with a good attack for the pawns, but Black is still in the game.

**11. bc3** **Qc3**

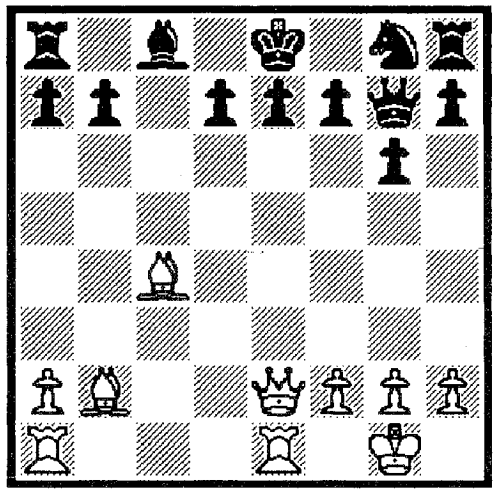
**12. Qe2!** **Qg7**

Not 12... Qa1? 13.Bb2 Qe1+ 14.Qe1 f6 15.Bg8 Rg8 16.Bf6 e6 17.Qb4 and wins.

**13. Bb2**

( See the diagram on the next page)





The ultimate gambit position! White controls every central square; his rooks are connected, his bishops raking, his Queen is nearly mating. Meanwhile Black's Queen (his only developed piece!) is pitifully huddled in a corner; Black's center pawns still haven't moved, and only represent objects of attack; Black's King is far closer to death than castling. In view of all this, the fact that Black is three pawns up is virtually meaningless.

You do not want to have to defend this position!

White brings another piece to the attack, and offers the cute variation 14...e6 15.Be6! de6 16.Rc8+ Rc8 17.Qe6+ Ne7 (forced) 18.Qc8+ Kf7 19.Re7+! Ke7 20.Qc7+ Kf8 21.Ba3+ Kg8 22

**13...** **f6**

**14. Rac1**

.Qd8+ Kf7 23.Qd7+ Kg8 24.Qe8+ and mates.

**14...** **g5**

**15. Ba3** **e5**

**16. f4!**

What's a fourth pawn among friends?

**16... gf4**
**17. Qh5+ Kd8**

17... Qg6 loses more quickly to 18.Re5+! Kd8 19.Bf7! and mates at e8.

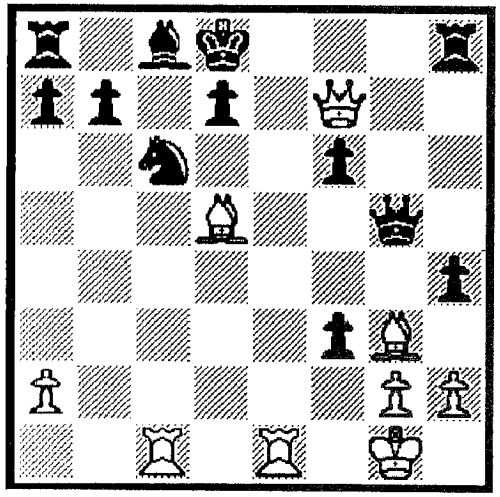
**18. Bd6**

Blockade: the Black d pawn should have advanced on move five, but it's too late now.

**18... Ne7**
**19. Re5!**

If 19... fe5 20.Bf7 wins.

**19... Nc6**
**20. Ree1 Qg5**
**21. Qf7 f3**
**22. Bg3 h5**
**23. Bd5 h4**



White to move and win

**24. Rc6?**

This isn't it! This unnecessary sacrifice is a surprising error after White's exemplary attacking play - now Black can survive to an ending. Instead the simple 24.Bc6 wins quickly in all variations:



24... bc6 25.Qe7 Mate; 24... dc6 25.Qe7 Mate; 24... hg3 25.Qe7+ Kc7 26.Bd5+ and mates shortly; 24... f2+ 25.Bf2 bc6 26.Rc6 f5 27.Rg6 wins at least a Rook.

**24... f2+**
**25. Bf2 bc6**
**26. Bc6 Rb8**

I don't know what White overlooked, but at this point he must have realized that he has no mate. Fortunately, the White attack is so strong that he can still obtain the advantage by playing for material gain.

**27. Qe7 Kc7**
**28. Be3 Qe5**

Since 28... Qf5 is met by 29.Be4, and 28... Qa5 by 29.Rc1, Black is forced to trade his Queen for two rooks - but of course having the Queen is an advantage for the attacker.

**29. Bb6 Kb6**
**30. Re5 fe5**
**31. Qe5 Ba6?**

Black, who has played an heroic defense ever since his bad opening, now blunders just when he could really make White work for the point. Correct is 31... Bb7 32.Bd7 a6 33.Qd6+ Ka7 34.Qc5+ Ka8 35.Qb6 Rbd8. Belenko considers this position to be won for White (objectively he may be right), giving the idea 36.Bc6. However, after 36... Bc6 37.Qa6+ Kb8 38.Qc6 White still faces a long tough ending before he will be able to see victory. I believe that Black has definite practical drawing chances in this ending.

**32. Bd7 Rbd8**

Loses by force, but it's hard to give good advice now.

**33. Qd6+ Kb7**
**34. Qc6+ Kb8**
**35. Qa6 Rd7**
**36. Qb5+**

No matter how Black plays, White picks up one of the loose Rooks.

**36... Kc8**
**37. Qc6+ Resigns**



## GAME 2: THE OLD MAIN LINE

Greene Taylor
Maryland 1982

**1. e4 c5**
**2. d4 cd4**
**3. c3 dc3**
**4. Nc3 Nc6**
**5. Nf3 e6**

In an experimental mood, I deviate from the best (5... d6) and try out the old main line, as given in ECO. I soon discover that this is another line that *Black should not play*: White clearly develops at least enough compensation for the pawn in this variation. The main problem with playing ... e6 here or on the next move is that by closing the c8-h3 diagonal and committing the e pawn it limits Black's options; in some variations of the ... a6 line one can play ... Bg4 (see Games 7 and 8) while in others ... e5 is possible in one go, thus gaining a vital tempo (see Game 9).

**6. Bc4 d6**
**7. O-O Nf6**

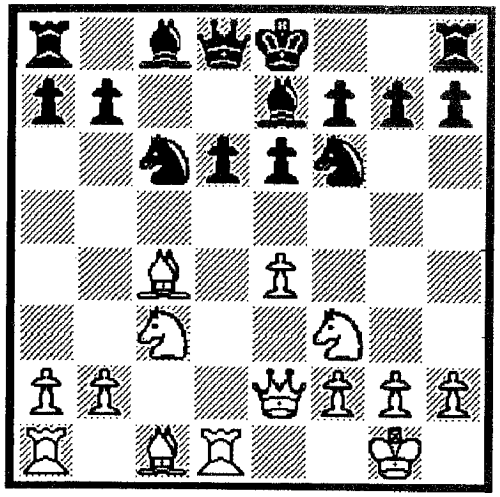
I also experimented with 7... Nge7 one time, inspired by Donald Byrne's win over Ken Smith at San Antonio 1972, but I can't recommend it. Black's behind in development anyway - it's not too logical to spend two moves developing the N to g6 when it can be more centrally located to f6 in one. Adkins - Taylor, New York 1975 continued 8.Bg5 a6 (Disastrous is 8... h6?? 9.Nb5 and White wins, Rizzitano - I. Ivanov, New York 1983 - a clear case of a strong International Master losing a full point through unfamiliarity with the Smith-Morra) 9.Qe2 Qa5 (If 9... h6 White plays Be3 and follows with Rad1, Nd4, and f4 to attack the Black Kingside and

the knight that appears on g6) 10.a3 Ng6 11.b4 Qc7 12.Rac1 Be7 13.Nd5! and it's obvious (even though I finally won the game following a tough defense) that I allowed White to get far too much out of the opening.

A risky but interesting line is the Chicago Defense: 7... a6 8. Qe2 b5 9. Bb3 Ra7 10. Rd1 Rd7 which will be considered in the notes to Games 10 and ll.

**8. Qe2 Be7**

**9. Rd1**



The critical opening position of this line: White threatens e5. Since the Black Q has no comfortable square, and 9... O-O is too passive, Black has nothing better than to block with the move I played, 9... e5. This means that the e pawn takes two moves to reach a square it could have touched in one.

It's evident from this game and accompanying notes that after this loss of time White has fully adequate play for his pawn. If



Black wants to get an opening advantage against the Smith-Morra he must play exactly on moves 5 and 6.

**9... e5**

**10. h3**

Perhaps even stronger is the current vogue 10.Be3 (as played for example in Walls - Brailsford, correspon- dence 1985), not fearing the pin 10... Bg4 as it is quickly neutralized with 11.h3. Black must watch here that his QB is not driven out of play on the Kingside - but taking the White KN gives White the two bishops as an additional compensation for his pawn.

**10... O-O**

**11. b4!?**

This quick attack is playable, but simpler is the time-tested development 11.Be3. Pokojowczyk - Gligoric, Yugoslavia 1971 continued with 11... Be6 12. Be6 fe6 13. Rac1 Rc8 14. b4 a6 (14... Nb4 15.Qb5) 15. b5 ab5 16. Qb5 Qd7 17. Na4 Nd4 18. Nd4 ed4 19. Qd7 Nd7 20. Bd4 Rc1 21. Rc1 Ra8 22. Nb6 Nb6 23. Bb6 Ra2 24. Rc7 Kf7 25. e5 Ke8 26. Rc8 Kf7 27. Rc7 Draw. Note that the famous Grandmaster never had any kind of winning chances in this game. Meanwhile, White's play is easy: he utilizes his open files and attacks the Queenside.

**11... Qc7?!**

It's dangerous to expose the Q in this fashion. Better is 11... Be6 12.Be6 fe6 13.Qc4 (but not 13.b5 Na5 14.Ne5?? Qc8 -+) Qd7. Now Boleslavski, in SKANDI- NAVISCH BIS SIZILIANISCH, gives a long forcing variation beginning with 14.b5 that leads to Black's advantage. However, there is no need for White to play this way - the more logical 14.Be3 seems to give him reasonable play for the pawn.

**12.Bg5**

A quiet move Sharpest is 12.Ba3 threatening Rac1 and b5. White has chances to get the advantage in this line, for example: 12... a6 13.b5 (13.Rac1 almost works, but after 13... b5 14.Bd5

Bb7 15.Bc6 Qc6 16.Nd5 Qe8 17.Nc7 Qb8 18.Na8 Qa8 Black has good compensation for the exchange) 13... Qa5 14.Bb2. White has active Queenside play for the pawn and the BQ is still insecure.

**12... Be6**

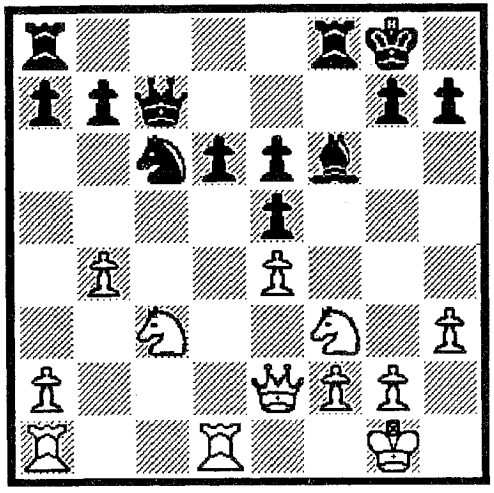
Pawnsnatcher's choice: if 12... Nb4 13.Bf6 Bf6 14.Nb5 with compensation for one pawn, or if 13... gf6 then 14.a3 and Black's weak white squares provide compensation for two pawns.

**13. Bf6?**

A bad mistake. There are two drawbacks to the move: first, Black gets better control of d4, and even more important, the harried BQ now gets a secure home at e7. Correct is 13.Be6 fe6 14.Rac1 similar to the Pokojowczyk game.

**13... Bf6**

**14. Be6 fe6**



**15. Qc4?!**

A better try is 15.Nb5 Qe7 16.Nd6 Rfd8 17.Nc4 (But not 17.Qd2 Qf8 exploiting the pin - in this variation Black does need to observe the blind alley 17... Nd4 18.Nd4 Rd6?? 19.Nf5! and *White* wins.) 17... Qb4. Here also Black maintains his pawn, but White



might claim some compensation based on his open Queenside lines and Black's doubleton.

The move actually played virtually forces Black to improve his position: now the BQ goes to excellent e7 square and White can no longer win back his pawn - and his compensation has gone as well.

**15... Qe7**

With the opening problems behind him, Black must now try to convert the extra pawn into a win.

**16. b5?!**

Better is 16.Ne2 to control d4.

**16... Nd4**

**17. Nd4 ed4**

**18. Ne2 Rac8**

**19. Qa4 d3!**

Black seizes the initiative, utilizing tactical threats to maintain his material superiority.

**20. Nd4 Bd4**

**21. Qd4 Rc2!**

The Black pieces cooperate beautifully - the main point is 22.Rd3 Rff2 23.Qf2 Rf2 24.Kf2 Qf6+ winning a rook.

**22. Rf1 Qh4**

**23. Qd6 Qe4**

**24. Rae1 Re2**

**25. Rd1 Ra2**

**26. Rd3 Rb2**

**27. Re3 Qd5**

**28. Qe7**

White's only hope is to try his luck in the ending. Avoiding the Queen exchange allows the Black pieces to assume dominating squares.

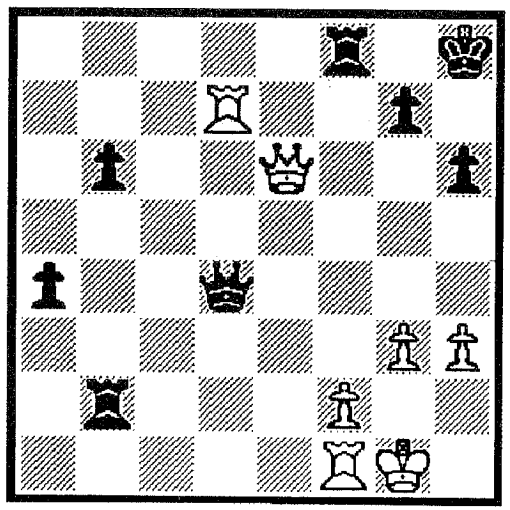
**28... Rb5**

**29. Re6** **Rb2**
**30. Re5** **Qf7**
**31. Qc5** **b6**
**32. Qe3** **Qf4**
**33. Qe1** **a5**

White's refusal to exchange has left him with no play while the Black pawns march onward.

**34. Re7** **a4**
**35. Qe6+** **Kh8**
**36. Re8** **h6**
**37. g3** **Qb4**
**38. Re7** **Qd4**
**39. Rd7**

This attack allows Black to end the game quickly with a tactical blow.



Black to move and win

**39...** **Rbf2!!**

Mate is inevitable.

**Resigns**



## GAME 3: KORCHNOI MISSES HIS CHANCE! FISCHER MISSES HIS CHANCE! ANNOTATORS FALL FLAT ON THEIR FACES!

Had Victor Korchnoi played the right move on move 9 of this game, and gone on to defeat Bobby Fischer, I would never have had to write this book. *Everyone* would know how to defeat the Smith-Morra. This Buenos Aires encounter would be remembered as, "You know, the game Fischer lost when he played that unsound gambit." And Korchnoi would have been a hero, his great accomplishment - smashing an opening and an idol with one blow - feted in every opening book.

However, Korchnoi failed to find the zinger and Bobby got counterplay.

Twelve years after this game, Larry Evans reached the exact same ninth move position against Ken Smith. Evans found the move Korchnoi missed, crushed the gambit - and nobody cared.

So life is unfair - let's go back to this memorable encounter, for the adventures therein are by no means over. Later in the game Korchnoi plays an incorrect freeing maneuver - he gives Fischer a chance for a sharp combina- tion that comes close to winning by force; and even after best defense Black would be clearly worse.

So Bobby crushed him, right? Wrong! Fischer missed the combination, and finally had to take a draw in a position where he stood slightly worse.

Adventures over? NO! Then the annotators step in with their two left feet. The game is given in full in BOBBY FISCHER'S CHESS GAMES, by Robert Wade and Kevin O'Connell; in

SICILIAN: SMITH MORRA GAMBIT ACCEPTED, by Ken Smith; and in THE MORRA-SMITH GAMBIT, by Janos Flesch. The latter two give the game score with the moves in the wrong order: their version does not transpose to the actual game until Black's *10th* move! By using this false move order they cut out the chance for Korchnoi to improve on move 9! At least Flesch admits that the position was reached "after a different sequence of moves" but he never gives the correct order.

Then Wade & O'Connell as well as Flesch give exclamation points to Korchnoi's faulty "freeing" maneuver that brings him to brink of defeat. Finally, all *three* books fail to mention the combination that Bobby missed - they pass over the worst mistake of the game in silence!

I don't blame the players for making mistakes under the pressure of tournament play - I've been there, I know what it's like. I do question the annotators, who have not exactly done a sterling job on this important if flawed game.

Following is my best effort at an objective analysis of this historic struggle.

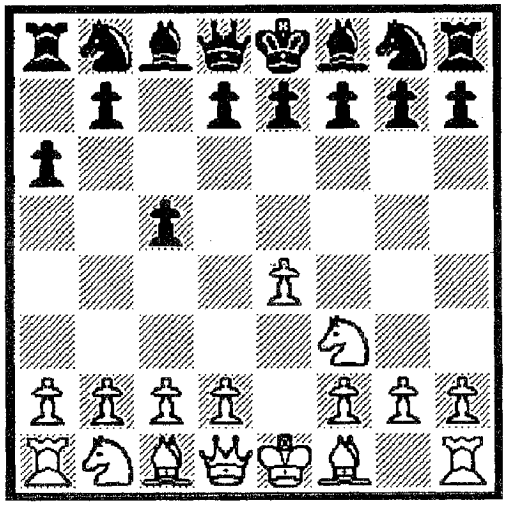
Fisher Korchnoi
Buenos Aires 1960

**1. e4 c5**
**2. Nf3**

Note that Fischer does *not* play directly for the Smith-Morra, as you would guess from Flesch and Smith, who give the first ten moves as follows: 2.d4 cd4 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 e6 7.O-O Nf6 8.Qe2 a6 9.Rd1 Qc7 10.Bg5 Be7.

**2... a6**





The O'Kelly variation: this is just a one trap opening, but it's good for catching the unwary or the inexperienced - note that Fischer was only seventeen at the time.

As any good opening book will tell you, White gets the advantage against the O'Kelly with either of two center-building moves: 3.c3 or 3.c4. In these lines there is little advantage to Black's rook pawn move; White's extra tempo is significant.

However, if White (like Fischer here) plays the most natural third move, 3.d4 (good against virtually every other Sicilian variation) he falls right into the trap: in this particular line, 2... a6 has a point!

**3. d4?! cd4**

My guess is that Fischer noticed the trick here: if he recaptures normally, there follows 4.Nd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 e5! In such Boleslavsky variations the only good N move is to b5 - but here the square is guarded by that seemingly harmless a pawn! White would have to retreat his N (6.Nf5 d5! is good for Black), say for example

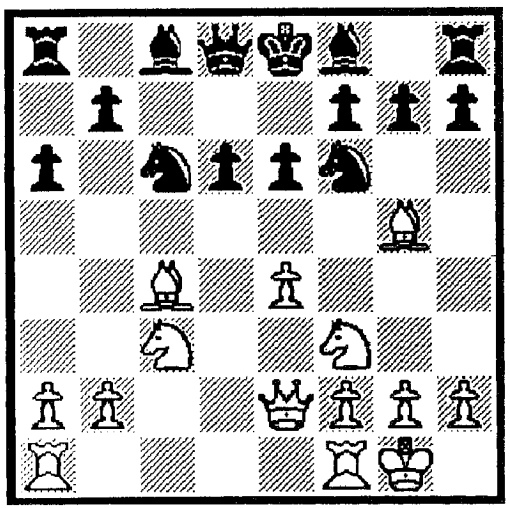
6.Nf3 - but after 6... Bb4 it's clear that Black has the initiative out of the opening.

Not wanting to be thrown on the defensive right away, Fischer transposes to the Smith-Morra Gambit.

**4. c3** **dc3**
**5. Nc3** **Nc6**
**6. Bc4** **d6**

We have now reached a position more commonly arrived at by the move order 1.e4 c5 2.d4 cd4 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 a6. I will analyze this sequence in more detail in the next game.

**7. O-O** **Nf6**
**8. Bg5** **e6**
**9. Qe2**



Korchnoi's chance to be a hero!

As we saw in the first two games, Black's Queen often comes under early attack in the Smith-Morra: d8, c7, and a5 - all dark squares - can not be considered certain sanctuary. It's important for Black to gain some early dark square control and maintain some



running room for the Queen. Korchnoi's next move, Be7, tends to box in the Queen, and worse, it doesn't contest White's plans.

The correct move, as found by Evans in Game 4 and practiced by me in subsequent games, is 9... h6! This move gains control of some black squares, with tempo, by putting the question to the White QB. Korchnoi is famous for his counter-attacking abilities: had he found 9... h6, thwarting White's opening initiative while maintaining the extra pawn, I think it is most likely that he would have won the game. And since Fischer would have been his victim, the game would have been reported everywhere.

However, Korchnoi develops quietly - too quietly - and now Fischer gets some real play for his pawn.

Please note again that in the false move order given by Smith and Flesch, Korchnoi would not have had this opportunity, for in their books the White QB doesn't come out until move 10!

**9...** **Be7**
**10. Rfd1** **Qc7**

Finally the Smith and Flesch texts agree with the actual game!

**11. Rac1**

As mentioned above, the BQ is already in danger.

**11...** **O-O**
**12. Bb3** **h6**

If 12... Bd7, Fischer could attack with 13.Nd5!, exploiting the exposed Queen.

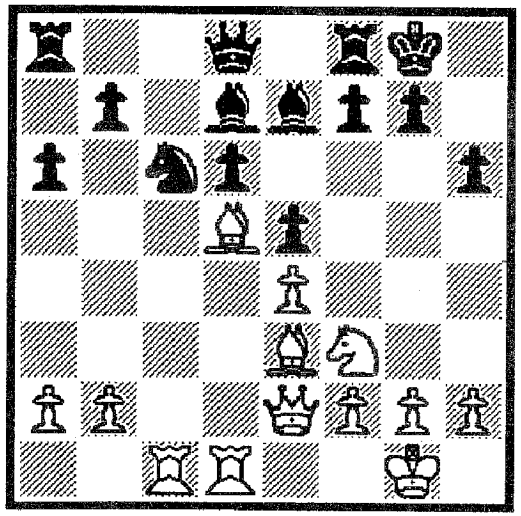
**13. Bf4** **e5**
**14. Be3** **Qd8**

Back home!

**15. Nd5** **Nd5**

Not 15... Ne4?? 16.Bb6 +-.

**16. Bd5 Bd7**



Take a good look at this diagram: you'll see it later in Game 10, Smith - Mecking, where I expose further mis-analysis!

**17. Nd2**

White has gradually developed annoying pressure, which at this point approximately compensates for the pawn. If Black continues to play passively, White might even stand better after he gets his N to c4, with serious pressure against b6 and d6.

Korchnoi correctly decides to buy off White's initiative by giving back his extra pawn - but he goes about it the wrong way. Black should take advantage of the momentary closure of the d file to play 17... Be6! If White takes his pawn back with 18.Bc6 dc6 19.Rc6 then 19... d5! with at least easy equality for Black.

White could also play 18.Nc4 or 18.Be6, in both cases with some compensation, but no real chances for advantage given that his strong KB has been neutralized.

**17... Nb4?!**



Flesch gives this move an exclamation point. My opinion, backed up by my upcoming analysis, is that this is a dubious adventure, misplacing the N by putting it on a non-defended, non-central square.

Better is 17... Be6, as given above - or if Black wishes to cling to his material and doesn't mind playing a tough defensive game, then 17... Rc8 comes into consideration.

**18. Bb3!**

Leaves the BN floating; Fischer doesn't fall for 18.Bb7 Bb5! followed by 19... Na2, when Black is fine.

**18... Bg5**
**19. Bg5 Qg5**
**20. Nf3 Bg4**

Flesch and Wade & O'Connell both give this move an exclam' - but now Black is almost lost. Flesch correctly points out that after 20... Qf6 21.Qd2 (note how this move gains time by hitting the misplaced BN) 21... Nc6 22.Qd6 White recovers his pawn with the better ending, but this might give Black better drawing chances than the game continuation.

**21. Rc7!**

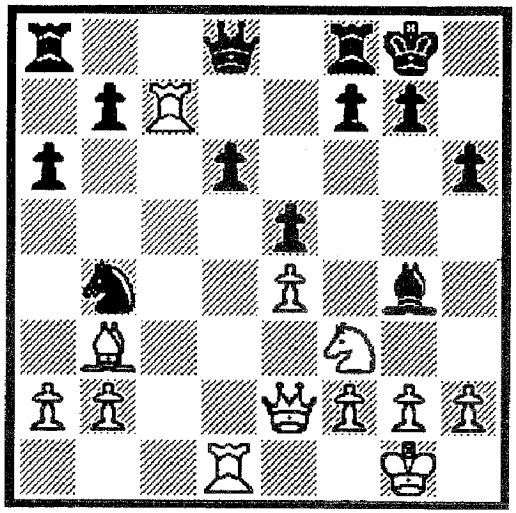
Bobby's in full attack mode now! Why does he forget this a move later?

**21... Qd8**

Black removes his Q from danger and tries to consolidate.

White to move and strike a powerful combinational blow

( See the diagram on the next page)



**22. Rb7?**

Wade & O'Connell, Smith, and Flesch all pass over this move in silence. Yet after just glancing at this position, I saw - as any master should - the possibility of a combinational blow on f7, based on the hanging BN on b4. Careful analysis shows that my idea is correct.

White should play 22.Bf7+!! Rf7 (22... Kh8 23.Rb7 and White is a pawn up while attacking Black's loose N) 23.Rf7 and now there are two variations.

A. 23... Kf7 (apparently the only playable move, this is what most tournament players - probably including Korchnoi - would play without much thought) 24.Qc4+ Ke7 (against all other moves White takes the BN with a double attack against Black's b and d pawns) 25.Ne5!! (Much stronger than 25.Qb4 Qc7 when Black can hold) 25... Bh5 (The WN is immune because of Qb4+ and Rd8, while the WR can't be taken because of the immediate mate on f7) 26.Qb4!! Bd1 (On other moves Black is just a pawn down with a terrible position) 27.Qb7+ Kf6 28.Qf7+! Ke5 (If 28... Kg5 29.Qf5+



Kh4 30.g3 Mate) 29.Qf5+ Kd4 30.Qd5 Mate! If Fischer had won with this glorious combination, forcing mate while a rook and bishop down, *his* achievement would have graced every anthology. But alas, it was not to be - and then again, Korchnoi just might have found the following amazing defensive resource.

B. 23... Qc8!! (A truly startling defensive combination - Black stays in the game by moving his Q off the d file while denying squares to the WR. I haven't been able to find anything better for White than the following return of the exchange.) 24.h3 Be6 24.Re7 Nc6 25.Re6 Qe6 26.a3. White has recovered his pawn and stands clearly better in view of Black's compromised pawn structure (three islands, backward d pawn on an open file) but the win is still a long way off. Nonetheless, had Fischer found 22.Bf7+, he would in all likelihood have won the game.

Why did Fischer miss the shot? Perhaps time pressure, perhaps a blind spot - he's only human, after all.

Why did other annotators miss this shot? They *forgot* that Fischer is not infallible, and so failed to look at his moves with a critical eye.

**22... Rb8**

Now Black consolidates by defending his Knight through White's Rook.

**23. Rb8**

I can see no way to make 23.Bf7+ work now, because of Black's defended Knight.

**23... Qb8**
**24. h3 Bf3**
**25. Qf3 Nc6!**

The Black Knight comes back strongly, heading for the eternal d4 square.

**26. Qd3** **Nd4**

**27. Bc4?!**

More accurate is 27.Qa6, when Black must exchange his strong Knight with an immediate draw.

**27...** **a5**

**28. b3** **Qb4**

**29. f4** **Kh7**

Black has a slight edge - a "*nuance de superiorite*" as Alekhine would say - due to his strong Knight, but it would be very difficult to parlay this into a win. Therefore Korchnoi (perhaps aware of his narrow escape earlier) decides not to tempt fate any longer.

**Draw Agreed**

Opening Conclusions, Part I: These lines are ineffective for Black because White is allowed to take the initiative, and so develop compensation for the sacrificed pawn.



## PART II
## THE ROOK PAWNS ATTACK: BLACK TURNS THE TABLES

The three games in this part feature the correct opening move order for Black (1.e4 c5 2.d4 cd4 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 g6 6.Bc4 a6!) and the correct follow to White's usual attack (7.O-O Nf6 8.Bg5 e6 9.Qe2 h6!). These small but powerful - and properly timed - rook pawn moves give Black the advantage, as will be demonstrated.

Move order is crucial in this variation. There is an older variation of the Gambit, featuring ... a6 on the *eighth* move, which must be avoided. The line goes like this: 1.e4 c5 2.d4 cd4 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 e6 7.O-O Nf6 8.Qe2 a6 9.Rd1 Qc7 and now 10.Bg5 transposes to Game 3, where we saw that White had sufficient compensation for the pawn.

Both Flesch and Smith say that White can force Black to transpose from the 6... a6 line to the 8... a6 line, but as the following games and analysis show, this is not the case.

### GAME 4: EVANS FINDS WHAT KORCHNOI DIDN'T!

Smith Evans

San Antonio 1972

**1. e4** **c5**

**2. d4** **cd4**

**3. c3** **dc3**

**4. Nc3** **Nc6**

**5. Nf3** **d6**

**6. Bc4** **a6**

As I said, move order is crucial here. Playing 6... Nf6 (while b5 is unprotected) leads to great difficulties: 7.e5! de5 (7... Ne5 8.Ne5 de5 9.Bf7+ Ouch!) 8.Qd8+ Nd8 9.Nb5 Rb8 10.Ne5 e6 11.Nc7+ Ke7 12.Be3 and White has a powerful attack for the pawn as many games have shown, most recently Carr - Sutton, England 1986.

**7. O-O**

A new idea is 7.Bg5 - see Games 5 and 12.

**7... Nf6**

Note the first crucial difference between the 6... a6 line and the 8... a6 line: Black keeps his QB's diagonal open for another move, so as to answer 8.Qe2 with Bg4 (see Games 7 and 8 for this variation).

**8. Bg5**

In recent years many gambiteers have lost faith in this move, recommended by Smith and Flesch. Eighth move alternatives such as Qe2, Bf4, a3, and h3 will be analyzed in Part III.

**8... e6**

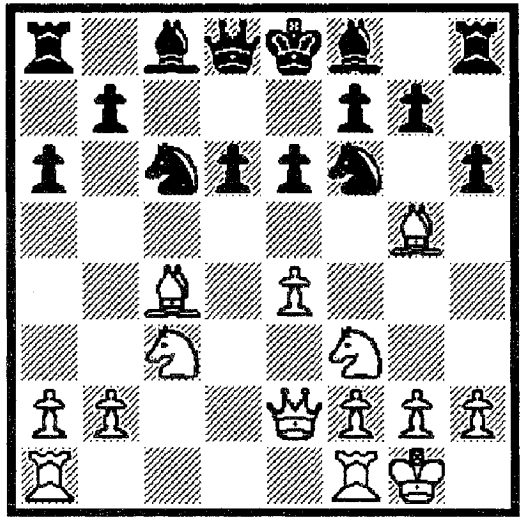
Now that White's Qb is committed and subject to attack, Black willingly closes the c8-h3 diagonal. Instead 8... Bg4 would be a mistake, as White could recover his pawn with 9.Qb3.

**9. Qe2 h6!**

( See the diagram on the next page)

What Korchnoi missed - what Evans found.
Where does the Bishop go?





Black stops White's initiative with this well timed counter. Now White has six possible alternatives, of which three can be quickly eliminated: 10.Bc1 is an absurd loss of time; 10.Bd2 is passive and blocks the d file; and 10.Bf6 develops Black's Q, fails to inflict double pawns, and gives Black the two bishops. Of the three main alternatives 10.Bh4 is seen in this game; 10.Be3 is tried by Rizzitano in Game 5; and 10.Bf4 is tried by Thomas in Game 6. According to Flesch (pg. 55) the latter two moves transpose into the old 8... a6 line, but such is not the case, as my analysis of the next two games will reveal.

**10. Bh4 g5!**

Black goes over to the attack without hesitation. His position is secure enough because of his extra center pawn; his Queen will soon be free to roam the black squares due to the elimination of White's QB.

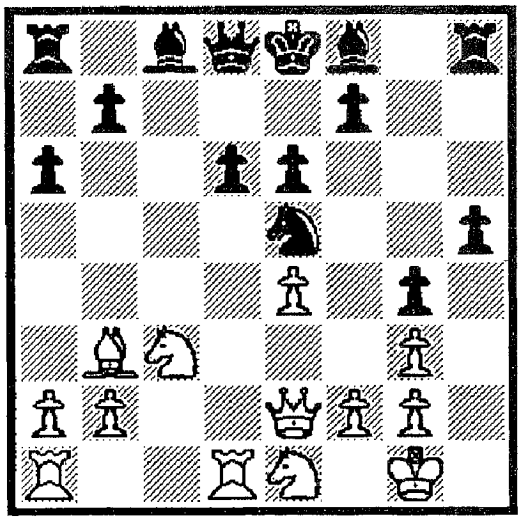
**11. Bg3 Nh5**

**12. Rfd1**

Better is 12.Rad1, so as to try to use the KR on the f file, but Black is still better after 12... Ng3 13.fg3 g4 14.Nh4 Ne5. In his line Black gets a good central Knight while retaining his extra

pawn - but he *doesn't* get the vicious Kingside attack we see in this game.

**12... Ng3**
**13. hg3 g4**
**14. Ne1 Ne5**
**15. Bb3 h5**



After only 15 moves Black has both an extra pawn *and* an attack - not a very good advertisement for the Gambit!

**16. Nd3 Bg7**

Another important point: Black avoided the too cautious 9... Be7, and now utilizes the unopposed dark square Bishop on a better diagonal.

**17. Nf4 h4**
**18. Qd2 hg3**
**19. fg3 Qb6+**

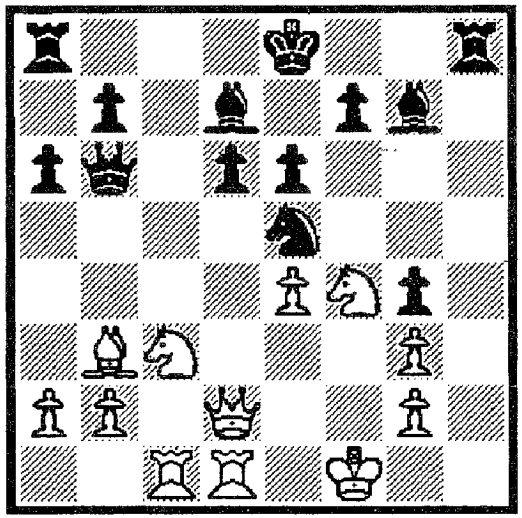
In most lines of the Smith-Morra, this move would be impossible because of a White Queen Bishop on e3. The absence of this piece greatly helps Black's play.

**20. Kf1 Bd7**



**21. Rac1**

Not 21.Qd6?? Qd6 22.Rd6 Rh1+ winning a rook.



Black to move and win

**21... R2d8**

Not bad, but as Evans himself pointed out, he could have ıished the game more quickly with the sharp and accurate 21... f3! White loses in all variations, as can be seen: A. 22.gf3 gf3 and e mate threat on h1 is decisive; B. 22.Qf2 Rh1+ 23.Ke2 Ng1+ 4.Rg1 Qf2+ 25.Kf2 Bd4+ wins the exchange; C. 22.Qd3 Qg1+ 3.Ke2 Nd4+ 24.Kd2 Qf2+ 25.Nce2 Ne2 26.Ne2 Bh6+ wins.

**22. Ke2 Nf3**
**23. Qd3**

Now White loses in similar fashion to the above note. Instead he could survive to the ending with 23.Qe3 Qe3+ (23... Bd4 also good) 24.Ke3 Nd4! and Black either wins the exchange or maintains a solid extra pawn.

**23... Nd4+**
**24. Kd2 Nb3+**
**25. ab3 Qf2+**
**26. Nce2**

26.Qe2 Qg3 or 26.Nfe2 Bh6+ are two alternate losers.

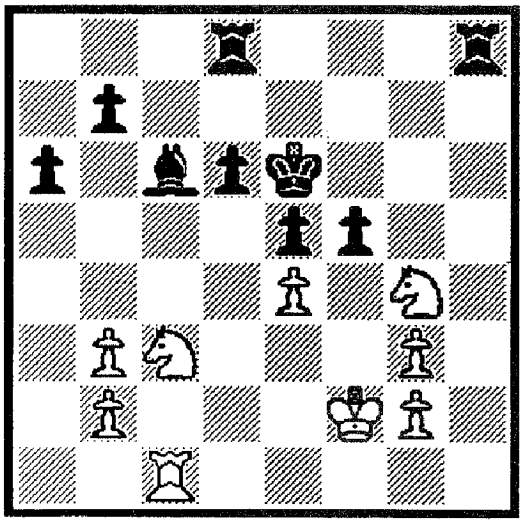
| | |
|---|---|
| **26...** | **Bb5** |
| **27. Qe3** | **Qe3+** |
| **28. Ke3** | **e5** |

Wins the exchange.

| | |
|---|---|
| **29. Nd5** | **Bh6+** |
| **30. Kf2** | **Bc1** |
| **31. Rc1** | **Bc6** |
| **32. Nec3** | **Kd7** |
| **33. Nf6+** | |

Makes it easy, but even on the better 33.Ke3 Black's material advantage will eventually prove decisive.

| | |
|---|---|
| **33...** | **Ke6** |
| **34. Ng4** | **f5** |



Black smashes the central blockade

Now Black obtains connected passed pawns and White can offer no more serious resistance.

| | |
|---|---|
| **35. ef5+** | **Kf5** |
| **36. Ne3+** | **Ke6** |
| **37. g4** | **d5** |
| **38. Ne2** | **d4** |



| | |
|---|---|
| **39. Nc4** | **Rdg8** |
| **40. Kg3** | **Rg5** |
| **Resigns** | |

## GAME 5: WHITE TRIES 10.Be3

Rizzitano Taylor

Heraldica Rusian International

New York 1983

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. Bg5** | |

A very interesting move order that hides a nasty trap. In the game Immitt - Boudreaux, Maryland 1981 the seemingly natural 7... h6 was quickly punished by the sharp 8.Qb3! In this position Black is already in trouble because the pinned e pawn can't block the a2-g8 diagonal. Evidently shocked, Black blundered and the game ended abruptly: 8... Na5?? 9.Bf7+ Kd7 10.Qa4+ b5 11.Ne5!+ de5 12.Rd1+ Kc6 13.Bd5+ Qd5 14.ed5+ Kd7 15.Qa5 hg5 16.Ne4 Black resigns.

Instead of this hari kari Black should have tried the far superior defense 8... Be6 9.Be6 fe6 10.Qb7! Qc8! (Too dangerous is 10... Na5 11.Qb4 hg5 12.Qa4+ Kf7 13.Ng5+ with a powerful attack for the piece) 11.Qc8+ Rc8 12.Be3 when White has only a small endgame advantage. Even so, this is not a line to recommend for Black!

**7... Nf6**

I avoid the trap - but now White can inflict doubled pawns with 8.Bf6, or try the untested 8.e5. Are these lines dangerous for Black? I'll try to answer that question in Part IV, Game 12.

**8. O-O**

Instead of embarking on uncharted waters, White simply transposes back to familiar lines.

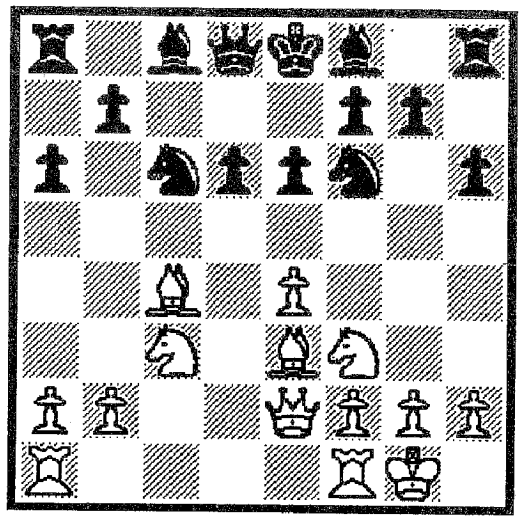


**8... e6**

**9. Qe2 h6**

The same position as Smith - Evans, and the same question: Where does the bishop go?

**10. Be3**



According to Flesch, the game now transposes to the 8... a6 line, but this can only be believed if one discounts Black's useful tempo ... h6 - and if Black is a *very* cooperative opponent.

I, on the other hand, think the h pawn move is useful - and I never like to cooperate with opening book writers or opponents!

The 8... a6 line, as we have seen, features the development of the Black King Bishop to e7 and the Black Queen to c7. Black gets a cramped game, and his Queen is often menaced on the open file - the whole line is not to be recommended. So WHY should I head towards that mess with 10... Be7 11.Rfd1 Qc7? Isn't there something better?

Yes, there is - something *much* better. The objectives of the subvariation 6... a6 and 9... h6 are to gain control of black squares while keeping the Queen as free as possible (which usually means away from the Queenside, where it is so often harassed by the White's rooks). With these ideas as a guide Black's next move is not hard to find.

**10... Ng4!**

Black gains a further tempo on the hapless Queen Bishop (if White allows the exchange of B for N he will have hardly any play, as we saw in Game 4) and clears the d8-h4 diagonal for the Queen.

**11. Bd2 Nge5**

**12. Ne5**

If 12.Bb3 Black can force exchanges with 12... Nf3+ and 13... Nd4, or he can go over to the attack with 12... Qf6, threatening to shatter White's Kingside pawns.

**12... de5**

**13. Rad1 Bc5!**

Black ignores White's discovery "threat" and places his B on its best square - isn't this much better than e7?

**14. Qg4**

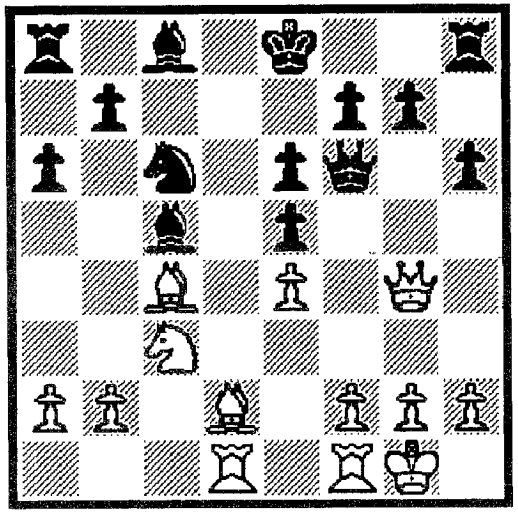
Not 14.Bh6? because of 14... Qh4! and wins - note the free Black Queen here.

**14... Qf6**

Another advertisement for the Gambit!

( See the diagram on the next page)





Black has better central control than White (the doubled e pawns do a sterling job, while White has a hole at d4); White has no attack; Black is a pawn up.

After only fourteen moves Black stands clearly better.

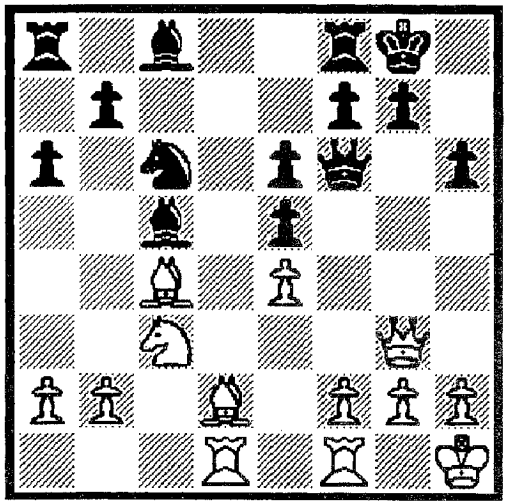
**15. Kh1 O-O**

**16. Qg3**

White has to spend another tempo preparing the f4 break, for the immediate attempt 16.f4? ef4 17.Rf4 fails to 17... e5! and Black wins.

White threatens 17. f4.
How should Black respond?

( See the diagram on the next page)



**16... Kh7?!**

Not best! The idea of this move is to drive the White Queen back even further, but I underestimated the dangers involved in putting my Queen and King on the same diagonal. The result is that I give White more play than he deserves.

Instead Black can retain a large advantage, while denying White counterplay, with the accurate 16... b5! White has three replies:

A. 16.Bb3 Nd4 17.f4 Nb3! (the key idea that I failed to see during the game - Black is willing to temporarily sacrifice one of his center pawns to secure the better ending) 18.fe5 Qg6! 19.Qg6 fg6 20.ab3 Bb7 -/+. Black should win this ending because of his two bishops, shut out White King, and the extreme vulnerability of White's doubled e pawns.

B. 16.Bd3 Bb7 17.f4 Rad8! 18.fe5 (18.f5 ef5 19.ef5 Nd4 -/+) 18... Qg6! 19.Qg6 fg6 and again Black should win the ending. Here White has kept his bishops, but his e pawns are much weaker



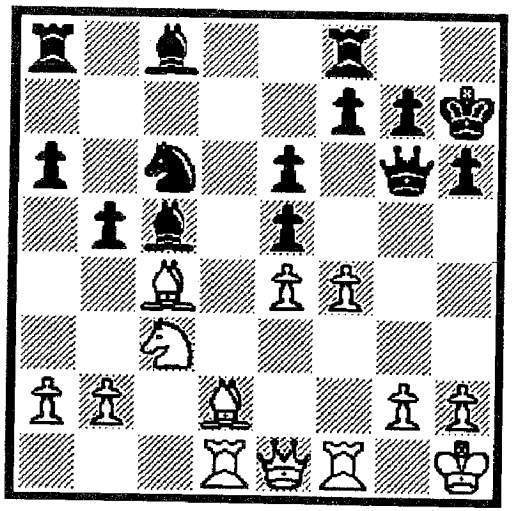
and at least one will fall in a few moves. The cut off White King is once again a "witness for the prosecution".

C. 16.Be2 Bb7 17.f4 Rad8 18.fe5 Qg6! with the familiar advantage.

I should have taken thirty minutes on this move instead of only eight!

**17. f4 Qg6**

**18. Qe1 b5**



White with a chance to get back into the game

**19. f5??**

Clearly *not* the way to go - after this blunder, White is not just worse - he's dead lost.

The right move is 20.Bd3, threatening 21.f5, while setting up a bizarre tactic: if 20... ef4 21.Be3! (protecting the KB with tempo) 21... Be3 22.e5 Ne5 23.Bg6+ Ng6 reaching a crazy position where Black has two bishops and three pawns for the Q - let's just call it unclear. In any case this is far better for White than the game.

I probably would not have gone in for that craziness, but even after the solid 20... f6 (instead of 20... ef4) 21.f5 ef5 22.ef5 White has some real attacking chances against Black's cramped Kingside.

**19... ef5**
**20. ef5 Bf5**
**21. Rf5**

Evidently hoping for 21... Qf5? 22.Be3! exploiting the diagonal as in the above note - but Black's next ruins his dreams.

**21... bc4!**

Decisive! Without the white-squared Bishop there is no attack, and now Black is *two* pawns up.

**22. Qf1 Rad8**
**23. Bc1 Rd1**
**24. Nd1 Rd8**
**25. Nc3**

White can't take the f pawn on this or the next move due to easy back rank mating combinations.

**25... Bd4**
**26. Ne4 Ne7!**

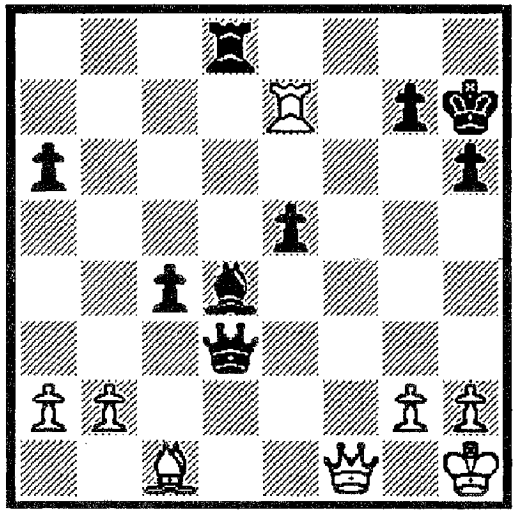
Black finishes with style!

**27. Rf7 Qe4**
**28. Re7 Qd3!!**

Does White have a playable move?

( See the diagram on the next page)





Black threatens mate on the move. The first five variations look grim for White:

A. 29.Qd3 cd3 and the connected passed pawns win.

B. 29.Qf3 Rf8! 30.Rg7+ Kg7 31.Bh6+ Kh7! 32.Qd3+ cd3 33.Bf8 d2 and Queens.

C. 29.Qe1 Rf8 wins the Queen.

D. 29.Rg7+ Kg7 30.Bh6+ Kg6! and Black is a rook up.

E. 29.Rf7 Qf1+ 30.Rf1 Rb8 and Black will be two pawns up in a simple ending.

So White found a sixth alternative which is clearly the best:

**Resigns!**

## GAME 6: WHITE TRIES 10.Bf4

Thomas Taylor
US Team Championship
New Jersey 1973

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |
| **8. Bg5** | **e6** |
| **9. Qe2** | **h6** |

The familiar kick.

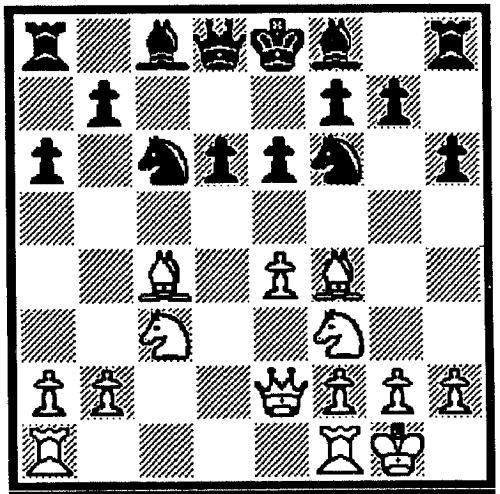
**10. Bf4**

This retreat of the QB is considered best by both Smith and Flesch. The latter comments on page 55 of THE MORRA-SMITH GAMBIT, "The game transposes into variations of the 8... a6 line."

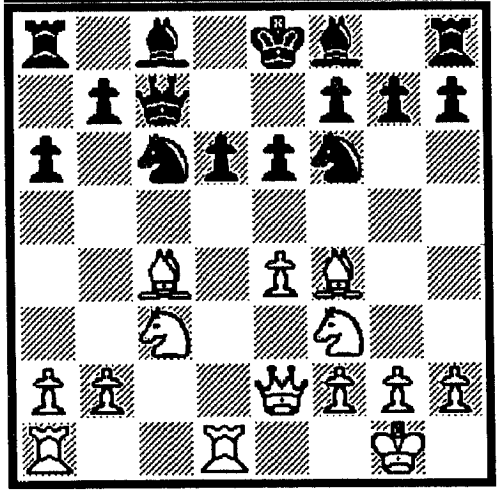
Now I don't wish to belabor the point more than necessary, but it's important to realize that the above statement is completely false: the 6... a6 line is quite different from the old fashioned 8... a6 line, and no transposition is possible, so long as logic and the laws of chess exist.

Here are, once again, the moves of the 8... a6 line: 1.e4 c5 2.d4 cd4 3.c3 dc3 4.Nc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 e6 7.O-O Nf6 8.Qe2 a6 9.Rd1 Qc7 and now White could play 10.Bf4 as in the present game. The two positions reached are quite different, as can be seen.





The 6...a6 line after 10. Bf4 (Thomas - Taylor)



The 8...a6 line after 10. Bf4 (Flesch variation)

In the first diagram White's Rook is still at f1 because his Queen Bishop has taken two moves to reach f4. Black has a pawn at h6, and his Queen is well placed on her original square (rather than exposed on c7). In the second diagram White has various factors in his favor: his King Rook is already on d1, the Black Queen is badly placed on the open c file and in the line of the White Queen Bishop, and Black does not have the useful tempo ... h6.

To reach the second diagram from the first, to 'transpose', as Flesch says, is only possible if one combines the illogical with the illegal. Black would have to play the strange 10... Qc7 (putting the Queen in the path of the White Queen Bishop and soon the White Queen Rook) and then *on the same turn* retract a move (!) by sliding his h pawn from h6 *back* to h7. Then White could play 11.Rd1 and indeed a variation of the 8... a6 line would appear!

Sad to say, I chose not to play such an "original" continuation!

**10... g5!?**

I considered two logical candidate moves on this turn, 10... g5 (which I eventually played) and 10... e5. Even now, after analysis, it's hard to tell which is better - they're both good and the choice is essentially a matter of style.

I chose to go over to the attack immediately, disregarding the loosening of my position - this is somewhat risky, but aggressive chess.

On the other hand, the solid 10... e5 has its merits. After 11.Be3 Be7 12.Rd1 a variation of the Old Main Line (Game 2, note to move 10) would be reached in which Black has two extra tempi, the pawn moves ... a6 and ... h6. Both of these moves are useful in restricting White's pieces. Since the Old Main Line is about equal, the inclusion of these extra moves should tip the balance in Black's favor. Still, it must be admitted that these little rook pawn advances are strictly defensive in nature, and Black will have to play patiently for some time before he'll be able to use his material advantage.

I wasn't feeling very patient during this game!



Note, however, that I willingly go into a similar two tempi up variation of the Old Main Line (Game 9) when my second extra tempo is the more fulfilling O-O instead of ... h6.

**11. Be3**

The White Queen Bishop, questioned again, must still search for an adequate retreat square. Clearly 11.Bg3, transposing to Game 4, is not much good. The text move has its problems because of the following Knight attack.

My opponent probably rejected 11.Bd2 because 11... g4 forces his N to one edge or the other of the board: 12.Ne1 (12.Nh4 Nd7 forces the weakening 13.g3, as 13.Qg4?? loses a piece to 13... Nde5) 12... Ne5 with the initiative for Black, but even so my game would be almost overextended. After 11.Bd2 I might have played the more positional 11... Nd7, with the idea of Nde5 and Bg7, while the g5 pawn secures the e5 square against attack.

These lines evidently give Black some advantage, but at least Black doesn't gain another tempo off the poor White Queen Bishop!

**11... Ng4**
**12. Rfd1?!**

For better or worse White had to try 12.Bd2 here - as we saw in Game 4, once Black eliminates the White Queen Bishop he not only ends White's attack - he can also attack with impunity himself along the Black squares.

**12... Ne3**
**13. Qe3 g4**
**14. Nd4 Ne5**

The familiar maneuver: the N on e5 dominates the position.

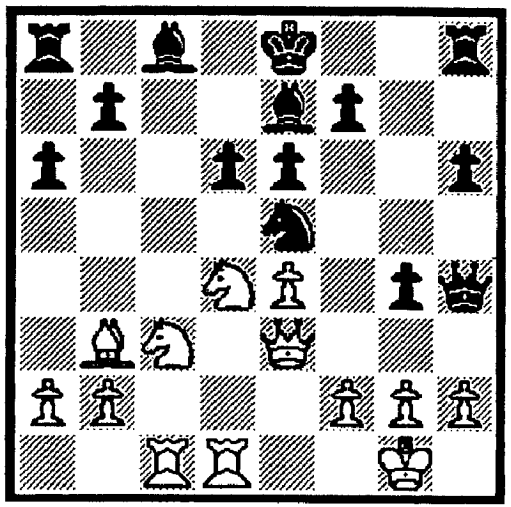
**15. Bb3 Qh4!**

The attack is in Black's hands. Note that this would never have been possible had I misplaced the Queen on c7.

**16. Rac1**

If 16.Ba4+ b5 and the piece sac is not good enough.

**16...** **Be7**



Still another ad for the Gambit!

After sixteen moves of gambit play, one side is attacking ferociously - unfortunately, it's the side with the extra pawn. Black threatens to win the exchange with ... Bg5 or to build up the attack with ... Rg8.

White can find nothing better than to offer the exchange of Queens, but this means that the opening struggle has been resolved in Black's favor.

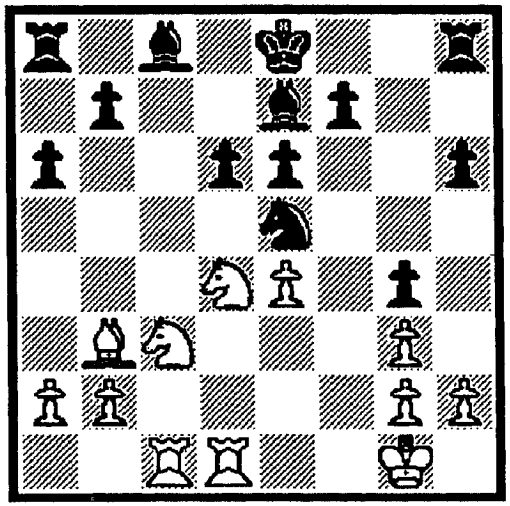
**17. Qg3** **Qg3**

**18. fg3**

What's the best move?

( See the diagram on the next page)





**18...** **b5!!**

With this move Black inaugurates a ten move combination involving a double pawn sacrifice. The positional point of these fireworks is that the game is opened for Black's marauding Bishops.

While the quiet 18... Bd7 should eventually suffice for the win, the forcing text must be considered sharpest and best.

**19. a4**

White is virtually forced to enter the main line of the combination, as on quiet moves Black just plays ... Bb7 with positional domination.

**19...** **b4**

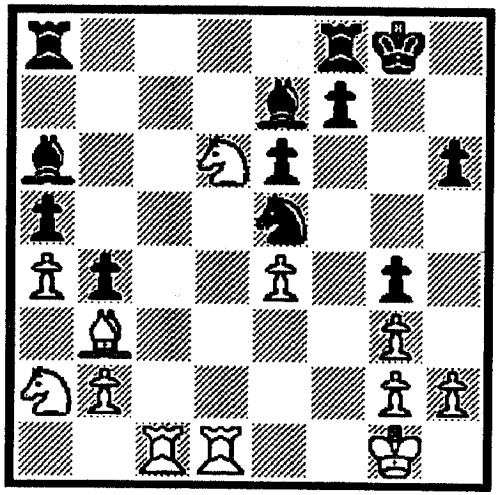
**20. Na2**

The Knight must move with attack (even though a2 is positionally a bad square) as on 20.Nce2 Bb7 Black maintains his positional advantage without even sacrificing material.

**20...** **a5**

**21. Nb5** **O-O!**

**22. Nd6** **Ba6!**



The effect of the first pawn sacrifice can be seen: Black's Bishops set up multiple threats, while the cramped and vulnerable White pieces can hardly function. Note that the cosmetically well placed White Rooks are in fact subject to interference (... Nd3) and attack (... Bg5).

I doubt that there is any move that White can play in this position that does not allow a forced win - the student may enjoy working some of these out (one simple but amusing example is 23.Nb5 Bb5 24.ab5 a4 and Black wins a piece).

**23. Nc4 Bc5+**

**24. Kh1**

Not 24.Kf1 Be3 winning at once.

**24... Bc4**

**25. Bc4 Be3**

**26. Rc2 Rac8**

**27. Bb3**

If 27.b3 Black forces the win as follows: 27...Nc4 and now:



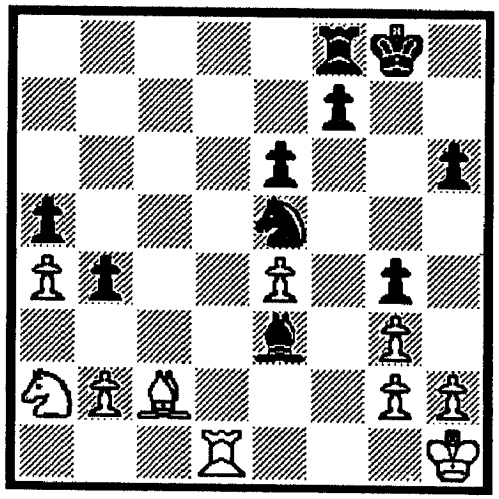
A. 28.bc4 b3 29.Re2 ba2 30.Re3 Rc4 31.Ra3 Rc2 and wins, because White has time for 31.Ra1 as 31... Rb8 threatens mate on the back rank.

B. 28.Rc4 Rc4 29.bc4 Rc8 30.Re1 (30.Nc1 Rc4 wins) 30... Rc4! 31.Re3 Rc2 wins.

Note how the back rank mates are a crucial feature of these variations.

**27... Rc2**

**28. Bc2**



Black to move and win

**28... b3!**

This second pawn sacrifice, which had to be foreseen back on move 18, is the point of Black's combination: the Black Rook breaks into White's game.

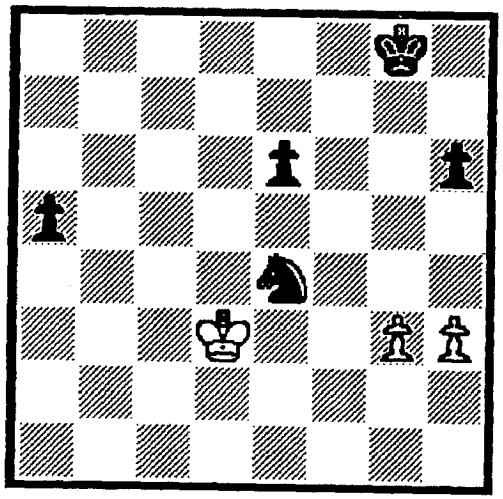
**29 Bb3 Rb8**

**30. Be6**

Justified despair, though not nearly as aesthetically pleasing as 30.Bc2 Rb2 31.Bb1 Bd2! with a pretty zugzwang. Black would

have his choice of wins in this position but the simplest is ... Nd7-c5-a4.

| | |
|---|---|
| **30...** | **fe6** |
| **31. Rb1** | **Rb3** |
| **32. Nc3** | **Bd4** |
| **33. Nd1** | **Nd3** |
| **34. h3** | **gh3** |
| **35. gh3** | **Bb2** |
| **36. Kg2** | **Rb4** |
| **37. Nb2** | **Rb2+** |
| **38. Rb2** | **Nb2** |
| **39. Kf2** | **Na4** |
| **40. Ke2** | **Nc3+** |
| **41. Kd3** | **Ne4!** |



An elegant finish: one of the separated pawns will Queen.

**Resigns**



Opening Conclusions, Part II: Black seizes the initiative with Evans' improvement 9... h6, and White has no good answer. The line with 8.Bg5 can be considered refuted.

## PART III
## WHITE TRIES TO IMPROVE ON MOVE EIGHT

Although the disastrous results of 8.Bg5 were not well reported in the chess press, they became known to advocates of the Smith-Morra.

The energetic and optimistic pawn sac'ers refused to give up. Thinking that their problems began on move 8, they tried practically every playable alternative there, including Qe2, Bf4, a3, h3, b4, and even e5. These variations will be considered in Games 7 through 11.

Through the actual games, and suggested novelties, I will demonstrate that none of these lines rehabilitates the Gambit.

### GAME 7: WHITE TRIES 8.Qe2

8.Qe2 is actually an old move which can be found in opening citations going back to 1950. After the destruction of the more modern 8.Bg5, this "tried and true" line was the first choice of most gambiteers.

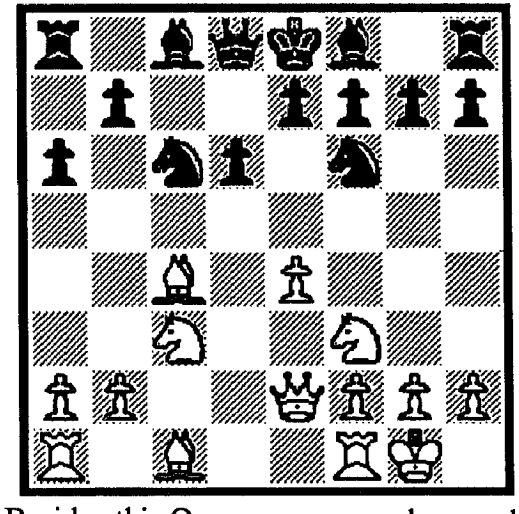
The idea of the early Q development is simple: White wants to get his KR to d1 with all possible speed. If Black reacts sluggishly with 8... e6? then White's plan works to perfection: 9.Rd1 threatens 10.e5, and Black is faced with the unpleasant prospects of misplacing his Q (9... Qc7) or losing a tempo (9... e5).



Of course Black doesn't have to lie down in this fashion, as both this game and the next will demonstrate.

Martinovsky De Fotis
Philadelphia 1990

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |
| **8. Qe2** | |



Besides this Queen move seen here and in Game 8, I will analyze in depth 8.Bf4 (Game 9), 8.a3 (Game 10), and 8.h3 (Game 11). Two less important variations can be briefly considered:

A. 8.e5 de5 9.Qd8+ Nd8 10.Ne5 (For this endgame attack to have any real punch, White needs Nb5 as in the note to move 6,

Game 4. Here that square is unavailable, so Black consolidates with relative ease.) 10... e6 11.Rd1 Be7 12.Be3 Nd7 (even the simple 12... Nc6 is possible) 13.Nf3 Nc6 14.Rac1 O-O 15.Be2 Nf6 16.Bb6 e5 and White had nothing for the pawn in Gooris - Schmidt, Aalborg 1981 (0-1, 43 moves).

B. 8.b4 (with the idea 8... Nb4? 9.Qb3) 8... Bg4 9.b5 (in this type of position 9.Qb3 is normally a fork, but here Black's b pawn is sheltered by White's) 9... ab5 (Simplest and best. In Regan - Tisdall, Denver 1977 Black must have regretted going into the complications: 9... Bf3 10.gf3 Ne5? 11.ba6! Nc4 12.ab7 Ra7 13.Nb5! Rb7 14.Qa4 and in view of the discovered mate threat Black had to give back the piece. The game continued with 14... Rd7 15.Qc4 e6 16.a4 and the passed a pawn gave White a slight edge which he converted in 61 moves) 10.Bb5 g6 and Black reaches an excellent position of the King's fianchetto line, analogous to Nakhlik - Holmov (see note to move 7, Game 1).

**8... Bg4**

Best: this is why Black kept the diagonal open! As I mentioned above, this pin can be met by the Qb3 (b7/f7) fork following most of White's 8th move choices (Bg5 or a3, for example) but with the Q on e2 that threat is obviously not on. Now Black has in mind both a simplifying maneuver (... Bf3 followed by ... Ne5) and an attack (... Ne5 first followed by play against White's soon to be shattered Kingside).

9. Rd1

Carries out his positional idea, while preventing Black (at least for the moment) from exploiting the pinned WN (disastrous would be 9... Ne5?? 10.Ne5! Be2 11.Bf7 Mate!).

9... e6

By blocking the WKB Black creates a real threat of 10... Ne5. Both Flesch and Smith recommend 9... Bf3 at once but that puts White a tempo ahead of this game (no h3). Besides, as a



'higher authority' (Nimzovich!) puts it, "The threat is stronger than the execution!"

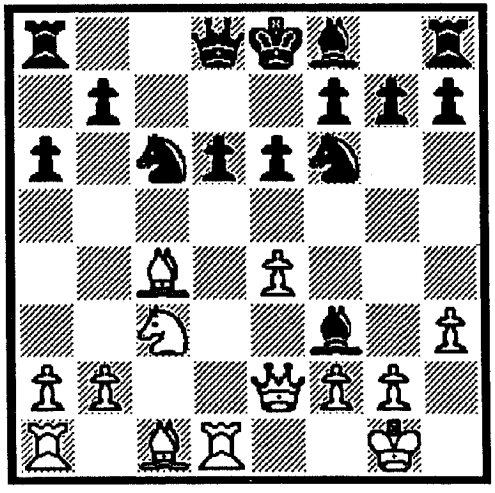
Why do Flesch and Smith advocate the precipitous 9... Bf3? Possibly because of following note in ECO, which states quite clearly that 9... e6 is a bad move. I quote Geller's analysis in full, from ECO section B21, note 61: 9... e6?! 10.Bf4 +/-.

Unfortunately Geller's note is completely incorrect, as Game 8 will demonstrate.

**10. h3**

White (wisely) decides not to trust the 'book' 10.Bf4; he tries to shake off the pressure immediately.

**10... Bf3**



How should White recapture ?

**11. gf3?**

This self inflicted Kingside weakness will have both short and longterm negative effects on White's game. The fact that the open g file does give White some play later is only due to Black's inaccuracies, not the merit of White's decision here.

Correct is 11.Qf3, when Black must play extremely accurately to maintain a small edge. Best play, according to my analysis, runs as follows: 11... Ne5 12.Qe2 Nc4 13.Qc4 (though Black has

simplified the position, he has not yet solved the problem of his weak d pawn - the following maneuver is the only way I have found for Black to preserve his material advantage) 13... Qc8 14.Qd3 h6! 15.Bf4 e5 16.Be3 Be7. Black has preserved his extra pawn, and his N (the point of 14... h6), so Black can immediately exchange should White play Nd5. Black does have a bad B and a backward pawn on an open file, so White has some compensation for the pawn - but I don't think it's enough. In the long run, Black has chances to make his material advantage tell, perhaps through a break with ... f5.

Still and all, from White's point of view, this is probably the most playable position he has yet been able to achieve against the 6... a6 line.

**11... Be7?!**

Too passive. I doubt White would have made it out of the opening alive had Black played the correct attacking move, 11... Nh5! I can't stress enough that the 6... a6 line is an *aggressive* variation. If you want to play this line, then banish all passive thoughts like: 'I accepted the gambit pawn so now I have to defend and suffer for a long time.' This is a totally wrong attitude. In many variations that we have seen (this makes one more) Black begins attacking ferociously on the Kingside right out of the opening. What's especially nice about all this is that Black keeps his extra pawn too, so if White blocks the attack by exchanging Queens (as in Game 6) then Black can simply shrug and win the endgame!

Back to analysis: 11... Nh5 threatens a powerful bind with 12... Qh4 and ... Nf4 (note Black's play on the weak dark squares, so characteristic of the 6... a6 line), so White's reply is practically forced. 12.f4 Qh4 13.Qe3 (awkward, but there is nothing better - if 13.Qf3 g5! 14.fg5 Ne5 with a winning attack) 13... Be7 and Black is a pawn up with good Kingside attacking chances.

**12. f4 Qc7?!**



The second dubious move - now White gets back into the game. As I have often pointed out, c7 (on an open file easily accessible by the WQR) is almost always a bad square for the BQ in the Smith-Morra. Usually the Q works better on the Kingside: therefore Black should have played 12... Qa5 here, with the idea of 13... Qh5. Black comes around to this plan in a few moves, which proves that ... Qc7 was just a loss of tempo.

**13. Be3**

An instructive blunder occurred in Blocker - Harkins, Ohio 1983, which continued as follows: 13.a3 O-O 14.Be3 Rfd8 15.Rac1 Ne4? Black probably thought he was making an advantageous exchange here, when in reality he was only weakening his Queenside and freeing White's Bishops. After 16.Ne4 d5 17.Bd3 de4 18.Be4 White's Queenside pressure soon led to the recovery of his pawn; and after a long endgame, White's Queenside majority gave him the full point.

Black should have avoided all of that with 15... Qa5.

**13... O-O**
**14. Rac1 Rac8**
**15. f3 a5**

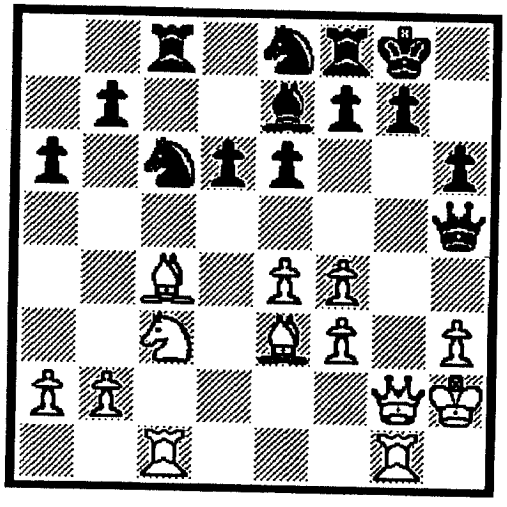
Better late than never!

**16. Kh2 Qh5**
**17. Rg1 h6**
**18. Qg2**

White wouldn't have had time for this move had Black not wasted a tempo with 12... Qc7.

**18... Ne8**

( See the diagram on the next page)



White has accurately exploited Black's inaccuracies, and has even made the g file an asset for himself. Meanwhile Black's blocked in KR is certainly not an ornament of his position. Now if White continues with 19.Ne2, defending his KB, indirectly preventing 19... d5 (ed followed by Ng3), and threatening 20.f5, then he should have adequate play for his pawn. Instead ...

**19. Be2?!**

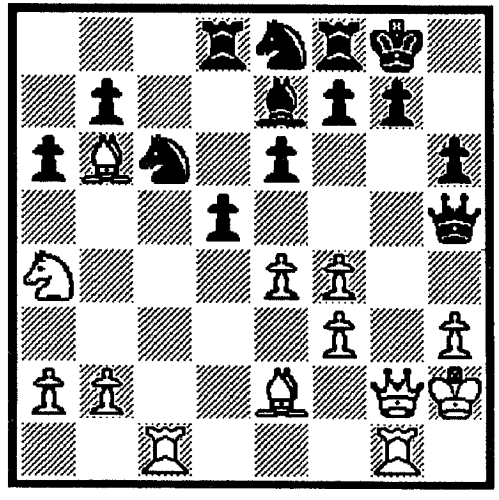
White plays an unmotivated retreat that allows the following counterattack.

| | |
|---|---|
| **19...** | **d5!** |
| **20. Na4** | **Rd8** |
| **21. Bb6** | |

Black to move and get back on top!

( See the diagram on the next page)





| | |
|---|---|
| **21...** | **Qh4!** |

Black comes back to the right plan with a vengeance! The ancient weakness at f4 is etched sharp and clear by this accurate exchange sacrifice.

**22. Bd8?!**

White has more practical chances in the pawn down ending following 22.Qg4, as then Black would still have some serious disentangling to do.

| | |
|---|---|
| **22...** | **Qf4+** |
| **23. Kh1** | |

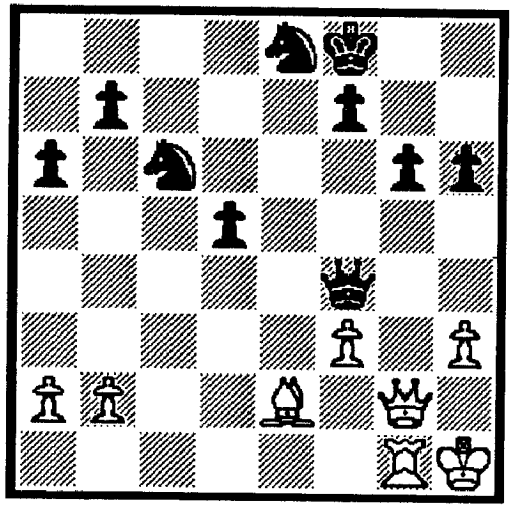
Not 23.Qg3?! Bd6! (threatening 24... Qd2) 24.Qf4 Bf4+ 25.Kg2 Bc1 and Black will win the ending.

| | |
|---|---|
| **23...** | **Bd8** |
| **24. ed5** | **ed5** |

Black has two pawns for the exchange and attacking chances based on the split pawns and weak dark squares around White's K. White could still stay in the game with 25.Nc3, centralizing this piece, but instead he embarks on a faulty maneuver that ends up ridding Black of his only weakness: the inactive R.

| | |
|---|---|
| **25. Nc5?!** | **Bb6!** |

**26. Nd7** **Bg1**
**27. Rg1** **g6**
**28. Nf8** **Kf8**

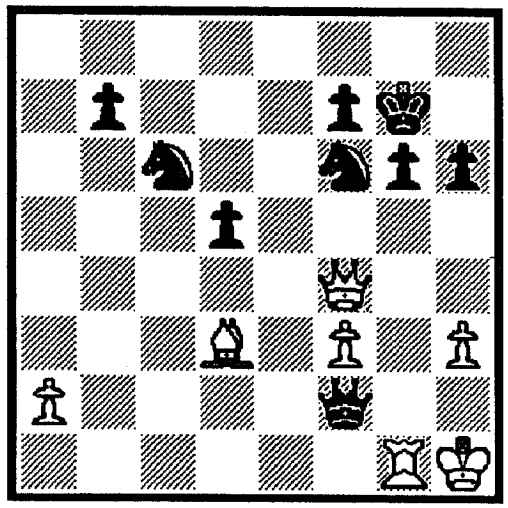


Now there is no doubt about Black's advantage: the Q+N attacking pair is well known to be stronger than Q+B, White's R is ineffective, and White's pawns are weak.

**29. Qg4** **Qd2**
**30. Rg2** **Qb2**
**31. Ba6** **Qb1+**
**32. Rg1** **Qb6**
**33. Bf1** **Nf6**
**34. Qa4** **Qf2**
**35. Qf4** **Kg7**
**36. Bd3**

( See the diagram on the next page)





Black to move and win

**36...** **Nh5!**
**37. Qg4**

Forced.

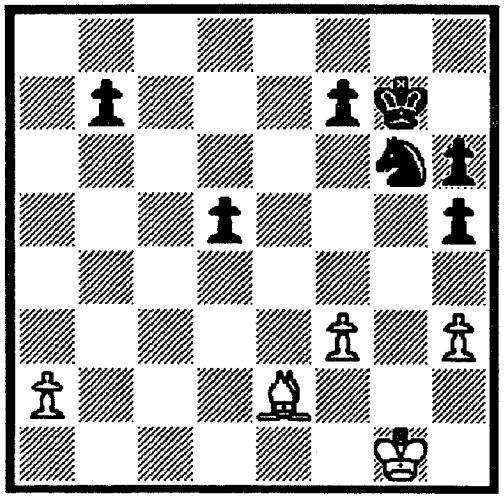
**37...** **Ne5**
**38. Qh5** **Qg1+!**

The point!

**39. Kg1** **gh5**
**40. Be2** **Ng6!**

The final blow.

( See the diagram on the next page)



Black carries through the idea of the opening variation (dark square control of the Kingside) into the ending. Note how the weakness at f4 (created when White took with the g pawn on move 11) finally proves fatal.

There are no more difficult problems in this game.

| | |
|---|---|
| **41. Kf2** | **Kf6** |
| **42. Bb5** | **h4** |
| **43. Ke3** | **Ke5** |
| **44. Be8** | **d4+** |
| **45. Kd3** | **Nf4+** |
| **46. Kc4** | **Nh3** |
| **47. a4** | **Nf4** |
| **48. Bd7** | **h3** |
| **49. Bh3** | **Nh3** |
| **50. a5** | **Nf4** |
| **51. Kb5** | **d3** |
| **Resigns** | |



## GAME 8: MAN BITES MACHINE!

Most chessplayers know the stories about Marshall saving up his famous gambit to play Capablanca, and Pillsbury hoarding his Queen's Gambit improvement for eight years to get his revenge on Lasker - but I guess I don't have the patience of those esteemed gentlemen.

This is my story: about three years ago I invented a crushing opening novelty that destroyed an opening variation of the Smith-Morra. The line was given in ECO as +/-; however, after my improvement, it would become plain to anyone that the position would be better evaluated at -/+. A full point swing, in other words - now all I needed was an opponent to fall in with my designs.

I played the Sicilian every time White played 1.e4 - but my opponents obstinately refused to play into my secret trap.

Then it came time to write this book, and I still had not found a victim - but then I met Zarkov.

Zarkov, a courteous gentleman of the old school (he always says "Congratulations!" when he loses), came on a floppy disk and fit nicely into my personal computer. He announces himself as version 2.61 - he plays a decent master level game.

He can also be "forced" to play any variation you want.

AHA!

So I set up the crucial position, gave us both 60 minutes for the game, and we battled under tournament conditions (no moves taken back, no visible analysis).

Two hours later, after Zarkov courteously congratulated me on my victory, I asked him for his thoughts about the game as it had progressed. He kindly provided me with a running index of his expected variations and evaluations (Zarkov uses a numerical system for this, where 100 equals a pawn ahead for him, and negative numbers equal advantage for me: thus -150 would mean that Zarkov felt that I had a pawn and a half advantage). I will incorporate some of Zarkov's opinions into my notes.

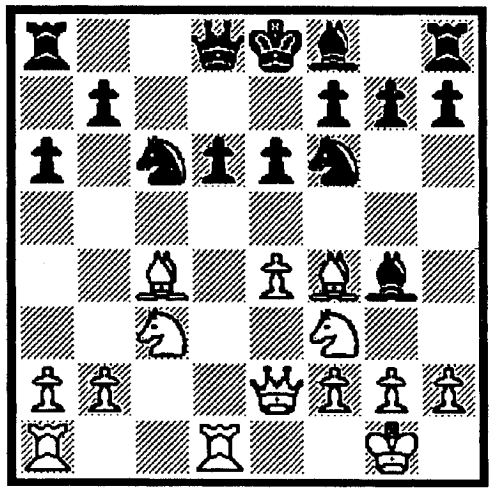
| Zarkov | Taylor |
|---|---|
| North Carolina, 1993 | |
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |
| **8. Qe2** | **Bg4** |
| **9. Rd1** | **e6** |

As I mentioned in the previous game, this is a dubious move - according to Geller!

**10. Bf4**

( See the diagram on the next page)





Now ECO says White has a clear advantage. How does Black overturn this evaluation?

**10... Nh5!**

The shot! This move is not so hard to find if one thinks like an attacking player: Black hits the undefended B while moving his KN to the Kingside; Black opens the diagonal for his Q; Black intensifies the pin on the WKN.

Much much much worse is 10... Qc7? (that misplaced Q again) 11.Rac1 Nd7 12.Bb3 Qb8 (moving again) 13.h3 Bh5? (Better is 13... Bf3) 14.g4 Bg6 15.e5! Nce5 16.Ne5 de5 17.Rd7! Kd7 18.Be5 (Getting still more mileage off the misplaced BQ) 18... Qa7 (A fine square) 19.Qd2+ Black resigns, Devault - Ludvik, correspondence 1968.

It's hard to find a more perfect example of how *not* to play against the Smith-Morra Gambit - note how Black's totally defensive attitude led quickly to his downfall.

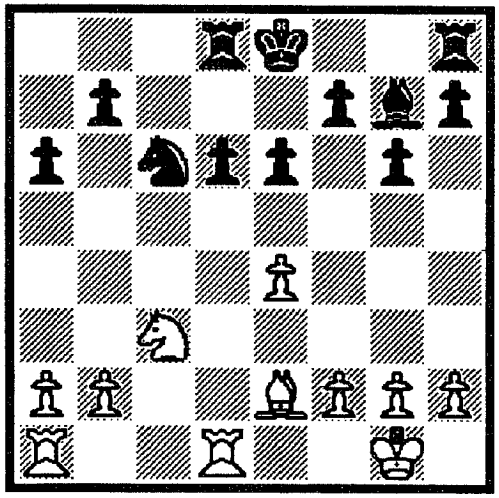
**11. Bg5**

Now Black gets a simple pawn up ending, but the alternatives are no better:

A. 11.Be3 Qf6 (There's no need to go into the murky complications of 11... Ne5!? 12.Bb3 Bf3 13.gf3 Qh4 14.Ba4+ with a sac on b5 coming) 12.h3 (Practically forced in view of the threatened 12... Ne5 and subsequent demolition on f3) 12... Bf3 13.Qf3 (if 13.gf3 Ne5 14.Kg2 Nf4+ 15.Bf4 Qf4 and Black's domination of the dark squares would probably give him decisive advantage even *without* the extra pawn) 13... Qf3 and once again White's in a pawn down ending - this time with the additional weakness of doubled pawns.

B. 11.Bg3 Ng3 12.hg3 Qf6 and Black is a pawn up with the two bishops and a strong position.

**11... Bf3**
**12. Bd8 Be2**
**13. Be2 Rd8**
**14. Bh5 g6**
**15. Be2 Bg7**





Zarkov gave this position a -107 evaluation during the game, which is to say I'm a pawn and a little position better. This is an absolutely correct evaluation - but what happened to Geller's "clear advantage for White"?

One may conclude that my attack with 10... Nh5 has conclusively refuted the 10.Bf4 variation.

**16. Rac1 Bh6**

Black makes use of a momentary tactic (17.Rc2? Nb4) to keep White off the c file.

**17. Ra1 Ke7**
**18. a4 Rc8**
**19. Ra3 Rc7?!**

As Fischer remarked in a similar context (MY 60 MEMORABLE GAMES, note to Fischer - Bolbochan) "I wouldn't have been awarded the brilliancy prize had I chosen the best line here. They don't give medals for endgame technique!"

I should have played 19... Na5 here, which shuts the WQR out of play, while b4 would just drive my N to a permanent outpost on c4. On other moves Black could simply build up on the c file: the win would be routine.

However, I played the text instead, which allowed White counterplay on the b line - and because of this, I had to find a dazzling combination to win!

**20. Rb3 Rhc8**
**21. Rb6**

Puts a little bind on Black - the N can't move because of the pressure on d6.

**21... Bf4**
**22. Bg4!**

Threatens to stir up trouble with Nd5+!. This threat compels me to abandon my c file pressure, and seek a more complicated way to win.

| | |
|---|---|
| **22...** | **Rd8** |
| **23. Ne2** | **Be5** |
| **24. f4** | **Bg7** |
| **25. Bf3** | **f5** |

The only way to make progress: Black breaks up White's center, but allows some counterplay.

| | |
|---|---|
| **26. ef5** | **gf5** |
| **27. Bc6** | **bc6** |
| **28. b4** | **Ra8** |
| **29. Kf2** | **d5** |

Admittedly the pawns look a little ugly - but now White can't prevent a break with either ... c5 or ... a5.

| | |
|---|---|
| **30. a5** | **c5** |
| **31. bc5** | **Rc5** |
| **32. Rb7+** | **Kf8** |
| **33. Rd3** | **Rac8** |

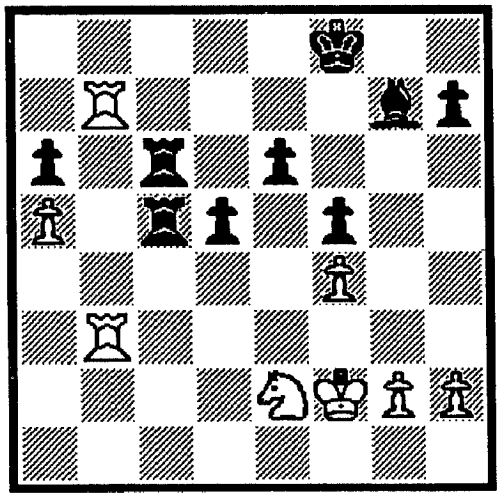
To meet 34.Rdg3 with 34... R8c7.

| | |
|---|---|
| **34. Re3** | **R8c6** |
| **35. Reb3** | |

The moment of truth: can Black take the "poisoned" pawn on a5?

( See the diagram on the next page)





**35... Ra5!!**

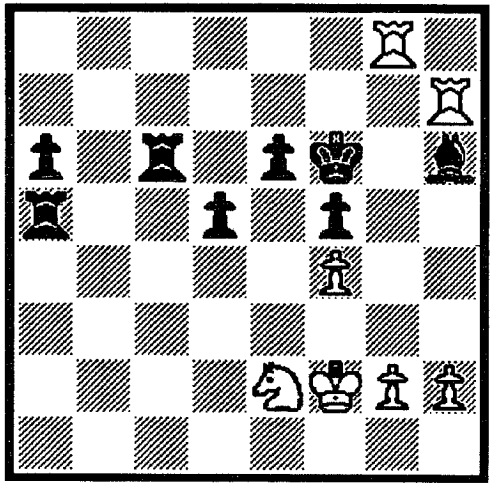
Yes! Being able to play this move is almost worth missing the correct and routine win of 19... Na5.

Zarkov was shocked by my "blunder". With alacrity, he quickly chipped out the following sequence.

| | |
|---|---|
| **36. Rb8+** | **Kf7** |
| **37. R3b7+** | **Kf6** |
| **38. Rg8** | **Bh6** |
| **39. Rh7** | |

Black to move and blow White's circuits

( See the diagram on the next page)



Apparently White will now win a piece for two pawns. Expecting this cheerful comeback after his tough defense, Zarkov confidently awarded himself a 37 - or about a third of a pawn advantage.

**39... Bf4!!**

The point. It was only now that Zarkov realized he had not won a piece at all. With what I suspect were many muttered imprecations, he unhappily changed his evaluation to -111.

**40. Nf4 Ra2+**

Exact. Black wins back the piece in all variations, as will be seen.

**41. Kg3**

Zarkov chooses the best defense, as a quick look at the alternatives demonstrates:

A. 41.Kf3 Rc3+ and mate in two follows.

B. 41.Ne2 Rcc2 and wins.

C. 41.Ke3 Rc3+ 42.Kd4 (42.Nd3 Raa3) 42... Rc4+ 43.Ke3 Re4+ 44.Kf3 Ra3+ wins.

**41... Rc3+**

**42. Kh4 Rc4!**

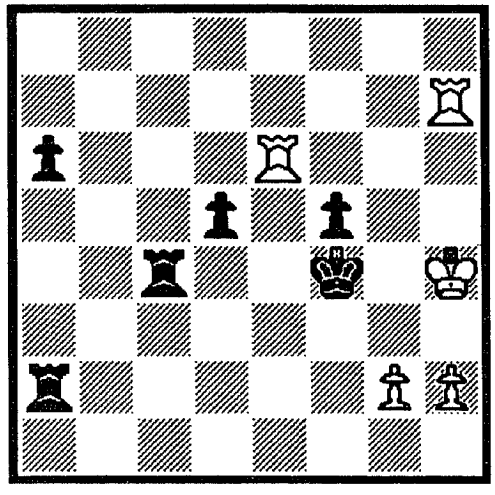


The key point, that had to be seen on move 35 (clearly beyond Zarkov's horizon) is that White can't play 43.g3 because of 43... Rh2+! which surprisingly wins not the WN, but the WR at h7!

Since 43.Kg3 Ra3+ is also disastrous, White must get what he can for his soon to be lost N.

**43. Rg6+ Ke5**

**44. Re6+ Kf4**



Now that the dust has settled, we see that Black has simply held on to the gambit pawn picked up in the opening. The reduced material is a concern for Black - but the speedy unopposed d pawn is a more important advantage. Meanwhile White is hampered by his misplaced King.

**45. Kh3 Re4**

**46. g3+ Kf3**

**47. Rf6 Kf2**

**48. Rc7**

You can't tempt a computer with a cheapo like 48.Rf5+?? Kg1 and wins!

**48... d4!**

Black gives up a pawn to advance his prize asset. Zarkov, in a fit of materialism, downgraded my advantage to -24, but he soon thought better of it.

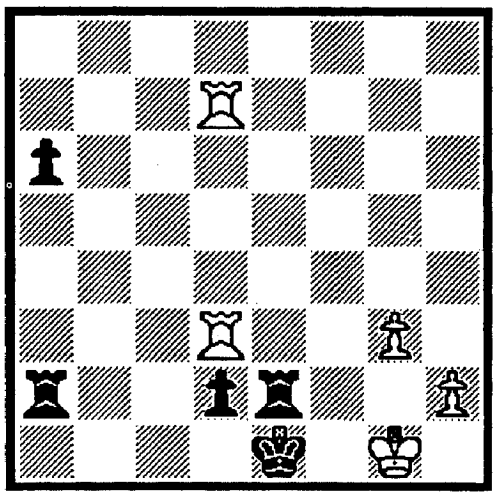
**49. Rf5+ Ke2**
**50. Rd7 d3**
**51. Kg2**

This doesn't help, but 51.g4 d2 52.Rfd5 Ke1 53.g5 Ra3+ 54.Kg2 Re2+ 55.Kg1 Rf3 leads to mate.

**51... Ke3+**
**52. Kh3**

If 52.Kf1 Rh2 is good enough.

**52... d2**
**53. Rfd5 Ke2**
**54. Kg2 Ke1**
**55. Kg1 Re2**
**56. Rd3**



Black to move and win

**56... Rg2+!**



After this shot Zarkov suddenly upgraded my advantage to -454! Clearly the R can't be taken because of the discovered check, so Black picks up a pawn and creates an "absolute seventh" bind.

**57. Kh1 Rh2+**
**58. Kg1 Rg2+**
**59. Kh1 Kf1**

Black threatens both 60... Rg1+ and 60... Rh2+; therefore White is forced to exchange rooks.

**60. Rf3+ Rf2**
**61. Rf2+ Kf2**
**62. Kh2 Ke2!**

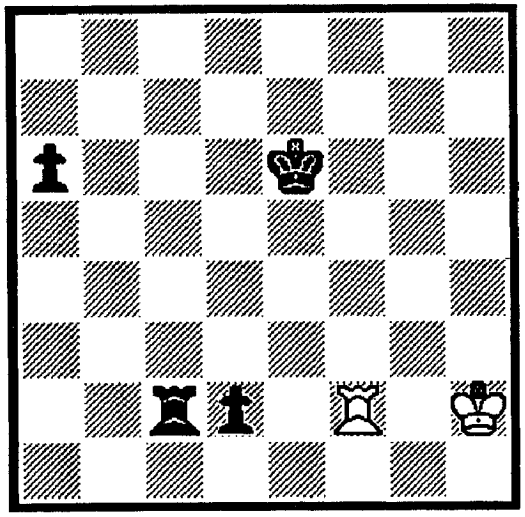
Accurate: by setting up the Queening threat, Black forces the WR off the d file - but this allows Black to move his K with a threat of discovered check, presenting White with insoluble problems.

**63. Re7+ Kf3**
**64. Rf7+ Ke4**
**65. Re7+ Kf5**
**66. g4+**

Zarkov indulges himself with a spite check.

**66... Kg4**
**67. Rg7+ Kf5**
**68. Rf7+ Ke6**
**69. Rf2 Rc2!**

( See the diagram on the next page)



The *coup de grace*: White must give up his Rook.

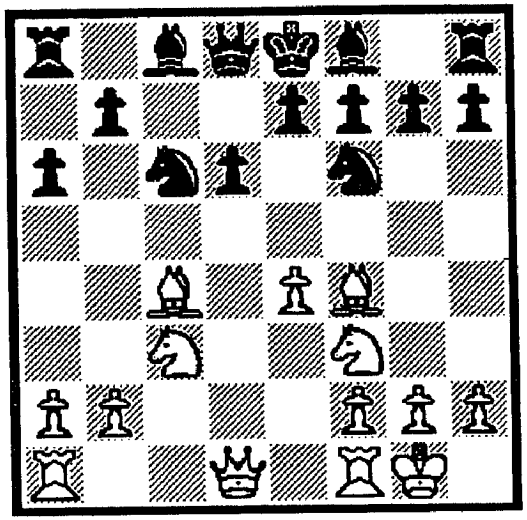
| | |
|---|---|
| **70. Re2+** | **Kd5** |
| **71. Rd2+** | **Rd2+** |
| **72. Kg1** | **Ke4** |
| **73. Kf1** | **Kf3** |
| **74. Kg1** | **a5** |
| **75. Kh1** | **Kg3** |
| **76. Kg1** | **Rd1 Mate!** |



## GAME 9: WHITE TRIES 8.Bf4

Wolff Taylor
New York 1983

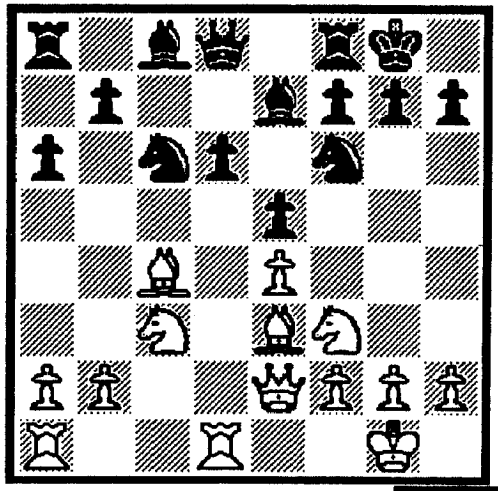
| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |
| **8. Bf4** | |



Here's another attempt at improving on move 8: White wants to develop his QB, but he's aware that if he sends it to g5 it will be driven back to f4 with loss of time (as in Game 6). Therefore he hopes to gain time by simply going to f4 right away. Unfortunately for White, this time saver turns out to be a time loser - Black kicks the B at once, and thus gains two tempi on the Old Main Line

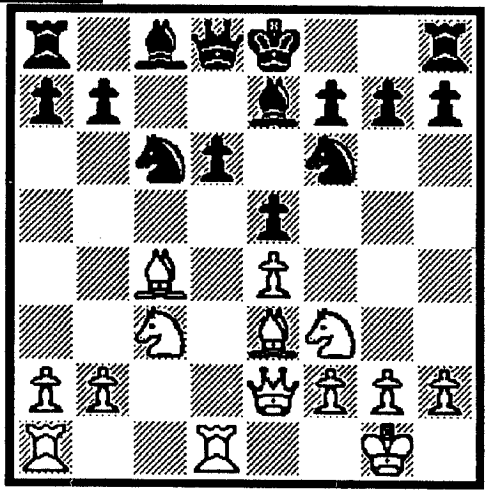
(Black's pawn moves to e5 in one stroke, and White's QB takes two moves to get to its normal square at e3).

**8... e5!**
**9. Be3 Be7**
**10. Qe2 O-O**
**11. Rfd1**



The 6...a6 line, as seen in Wolff - Taylor, position after 11. Rfd1

The Old Main Line, from the game Walls - Brailsford 1985 (note to Game 2) position after 10. Be3



Take a good look at the duelling diagrams above: it's clear that in the present game Black is two useful tempi (O-O and



a6) ahead of the standard Old Main Line position. These two tempi turn over the advantage to Black, for with his K in safety Black can utilize the a6 support and launch an immediate counterattack on the Queenside.

**11... b5!**
**12. Bb3 Be6**

In most variations of the Old Main Line White can take on e6 and play against the doubled pawns with Qc4 - but with the Black b pawn guarding this square, this plan is impossible. Also the BKR is ready to use the f file if it is opened.

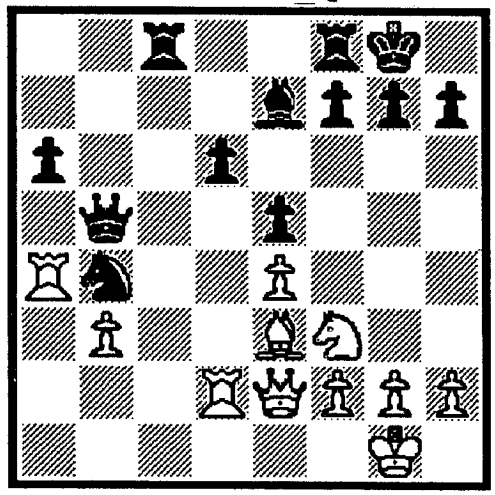
**13. Nd5 Bd5**

Of course not 13... Ne4?? 14.Bb6.

**14. Bd5 Nd5**
**15. Rd5 Rc8**

Black, with an extra pawn and a solid position, has a clear advantage. If White plays quietly Black will improve his game with ... Qd7 and ... f5 - therefore the future GM tries to mix it up.

**16. a4 Nb4**
**17. Rd2 Qa5**
**18. b3 ba4**
**19. Ra4 Qb5!**

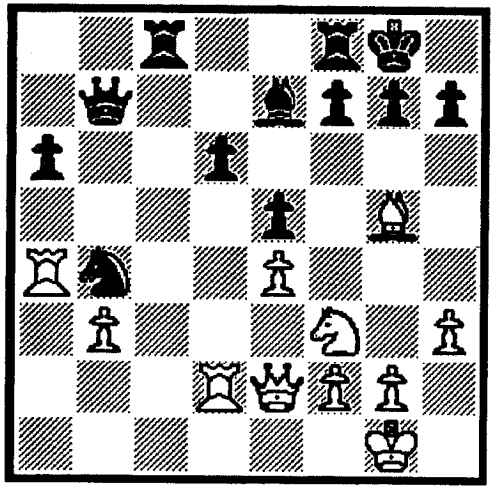


A surprising piece sac! Now if 20.Qb5 ab5 21.Rb4? Rc1+ forces mate, so White opens a flight square for his King.

**20. h3 Qb7!**

Best! Exchanging Queens is fine, but the middle game win - based on the weakness of the White e pawn - is quicker.

**21. Bg5**



Black to move and win

**21... f6!**

A surprising move, when one might have expected Black to rid himself of his bad bishop. However, now White's B becomes even worse - and more important, Black dominates the c file, thus creating a winning set of positional advantages.

**22. Bh4 Rc1+**

**23. Kh2**

White can't oppose rooks because he loses the e pawn.

**23... Rfc8**

Total domination.

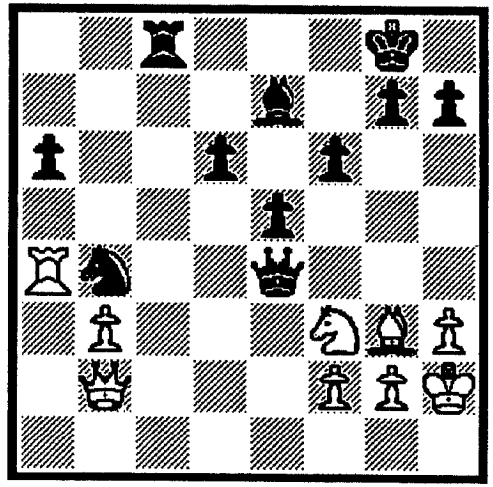
**24. Bg3 Rb1**



Black plans to double on the eighth rank, with mating threats. White finally opposes rooks to save his King - but then the e pawn falls.

**25. Rb2 Rb2**

**26. Qb2 Qe4**



Given Black's two extra pawns and sound position, White correctly decides not to prolong the game.

**Resigns**

Later Patrick Wolff gave up the Smith-Morra - and became US Champion!

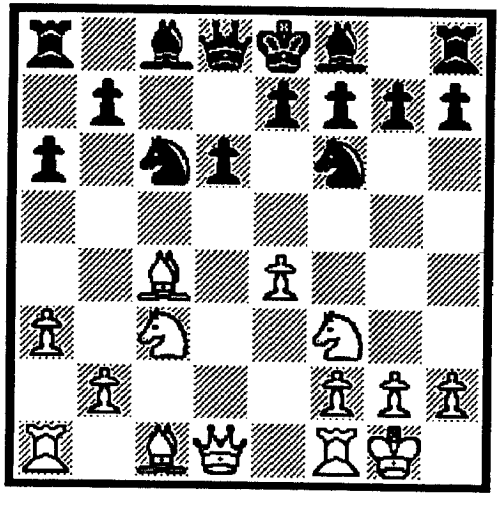
## GAME 10: WHITE TRIES 8.a3

This short game is notable for the serious, but instructive, errors committed by both players and analysts.

Smith Mecking
San Antonio 1972

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |

**8. a3**



David Levy, annotating this game in the book SAN ANTONIO 1972, somewhat unkindly asks, "What kind of move is this?" Indeed, it's hardly the sort of aggressive move one expects in a gambit. 8.a3 threatens nothing, and so gives Black a tempo to



improve his position. Black should get the advantage without particular difficulty - provided he plays *aggressively*.

Mecking, however, plays with exaggerated caution - and so Smith should have been able to equalize at one point.

**8... e6**

Simplest and best. Flesch claims that Black can get a good game with 8... Bg4 but this is mistaken on two counts: first, on general principles Black should not be so eager to give back his extra pawn; and secondly, the specific variation given by Flesch is flawed by a rather large hole. Flesch gives 8... Bg4 9.Qb3 (the standard fork) 9... e6 10.Qb7 Na5 11.Qb4 Bf3 12.gf3 Nd7 13.Be2 Rb8 14.Qa4 Nb3 15.Rb1 Nc1 16.Rfc1 Be7 and "Black stands well". Flesch goes on to extol Black's attacking chances relating to the weak dark squares around the WK.

Unfortunately, all these conclusions are meaningless, for it's hardly likely that White would play the obvious blunder 13.Be2? which Flesch gives without comment. Instead, I'm sure any gambit player would keep his KB on its main diagonal, and play 13.Ba2. After this Black can't get rid of the WQB, so White has simply recovered his pawn with a roughly equal position.

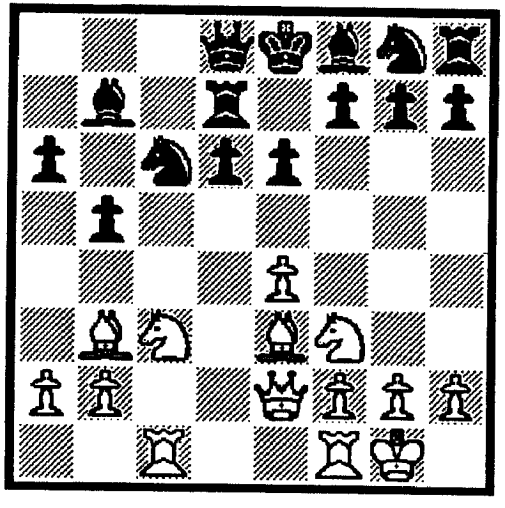
Therefore the 8... Bg4 line can be dismissed, as mere equality is definitely not Black's aim when playing against the Smith-Morra!

**9. Qe2 h6?**

What kind of move is this? I must ask. Mecking apparently does not yet understand the idea of Evans' innovation (Game 4 in this book) which was played in the same tournament four rounds previously. Evans' point, when he played his new move 9... h6!, was to drive back the WQB with tempo and attack on the Kingside.

Here Mecking has no B to attack, so the move just loses time. This squandered tempo allows White to play Rd1 next with pressure, which means that Black has given up his chance to get the advantage out of the opening.

How should Black play? The alert reader may recall that in Game 2 I mentioned the sharp and risky Chicago Defense to the Smith-Morra, the main line of which goes like this: 1. e4 c5 2. d4 cd4 3. c3 dc3 4. Nc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 e6 7. O-O a6 8. Qe2 b5 9. Bb3 Ra7 10. Be3 Rd7 11. Rac1 Bb7 reaching the following diagram.



Black has an excellent positional structure here, with his Q shielded on the half open d file, his QB aggressively placed, and his center pawn majority poised for later expansion. The sole drawback to his game is time: White is ahead in development, and Black has to get out two minor pieces before he can castle into safety.

White can try to exploit this factor with the sharp 12.a4 (Friedman - Dzindzichashvili, Chicago 1991) or the ultraviolent 12.Nb5!? (Mantovani - Vujovic, Milan 1985).



What if, instead, White played the inoffensive 12.a3? (Or, for that matter, the equally inoffensive 12.h3?) Then Black would happily improve his development with 12... Nf6, when the sac on b5 comes too late and a4 (besides being extremely illogical) will hang the e pawn after ... b4.

In short, *this* version of the Chicago Defense would be very good for Black - Mecking could have reached this position with correct play.

To see how this is done, let's return to Smith - Mecking: instead of 9... h6? Black should have played 9... b5! 10.Bb3 Ra7 11.Be3 Rd7 12.Rac1 Bb7 and Black has arrived at the improved Chicago given above, where 8.a3 can be seen as a pure loss of tempo.

Had Black played in this aggressive and confident style - the hallmark of best play in the 6... a6 line - then I do not think that White could equalize the game.

**10. Rd1 e5**

Now Black must submit to this tempo loss, familiar from the Old Main Line, and White gets reasonable compensation for the pawn.

It's important to say it again: the only reason Mecking is having these problems is because of his own excessively defensive play. Had he struck sharply with 9... b5 he could have been threatening White - with a material advantage - instead of being an unhappy defender.

**11. Nd5 Be7**
**12. Be3 Nd5**
**13. ed5??**

After this blunder, closing all attacking lines, the remainder of the actual game is of little interest. However, it is at this point that some astonishing analytical misrepresentations have been made, which I will set straight in the following analysis and diagrams.

Clearly White should have played 13.Bd5, and then after the logical follows 13... Bd7 14.Rac1 O-O the position is almost identical to Fischer - Korchnoi, Game 3.

Perhaps this proximity to the Champion caused the following bizarre case of analytic double blindness. Smith writes, in SICILIAN: THEORY OF THE SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT IN GAMES, 1968 THRU 1973, that "After 13.Bd5! White is *two* (Smith's emphasis) tempi ahead of the Fischer - Korchnoi game." Flesch writes, about the same position, "This is Fischer - Korchnoi, discussed in the 8... a6 chapter, but with two gained tempi for White."

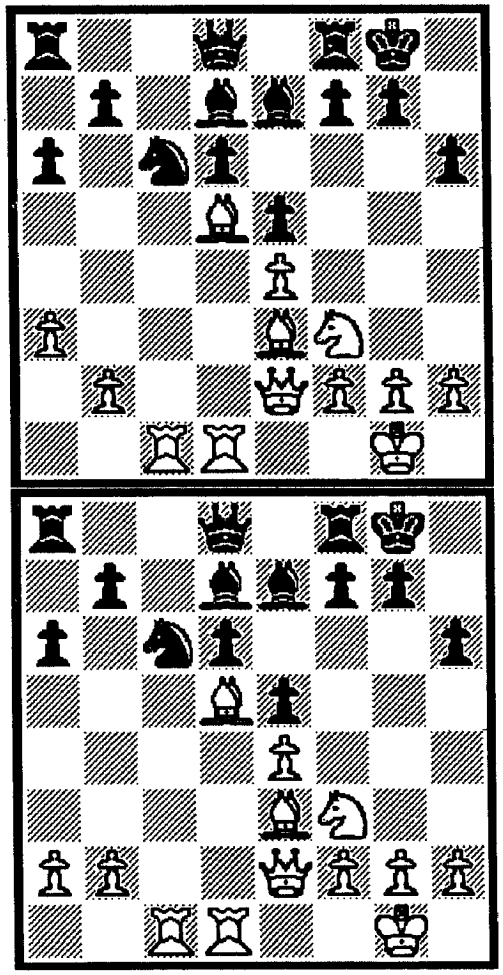
I must ask these *two* learned gentlemen whether they perhaps do not have *two* chessboards at home? If they do have that problem, then perhaps I can help out by supplying the *two* diagrams below.

(1) Smith - Mecking variation,
after 13. Bd5 Bd7 14. Rac1 0-0

(2) Fischer - Korchnoi,
after 16...Bd7

( See the diagram on the next page)





Take a good look at these diagrams. White is to move in both; all the pieces are identically placed; the only imbalance is that in the Smith variation diagram the White a pawn is on a3 instead of a2 as in Fischer - Korchnoi.

So it comes to this: the "two gained tempi" don't exist. White is in fact only one tempo up, that being the modest a3. White

should have approximate equality in this position, analogous to Fischer - Korchnoi; the *one* small extra tempo is not enough to change this evaluation.

Now let's return to the actual game.

**13... Nb8**

**14. Ne5?**

Another blunder, but on other moves Black would have calmly castled and won in due course with his Kingside pawn majority.

**14... de5**

**15. f4**

If 15.d6 Bf6 wins.

**15... ef4**

**16. d6 fe3**

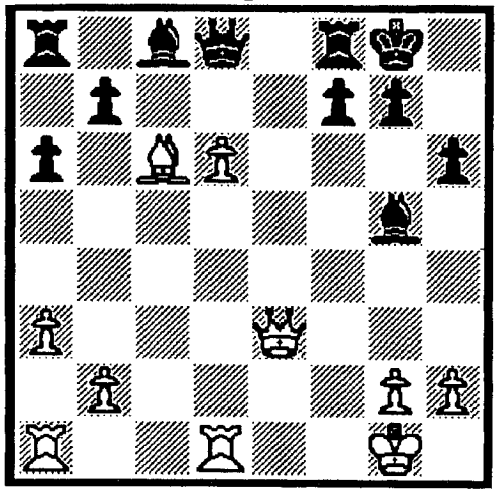
**17. Qe3 Nc6**

**18. Bd5 O-O**

**19. Bc6?**

Blundering a second piece, but 19.de7 Qe7 was just as hopeless.

**19... Bg5!**





Black gains a tempo off the Queen, saving his KB, and thus emerges two pieces up.

**Resigns**

## GAME 11: WHITE TRIES 8.h3

This game is another case of analytical boosterism by an advocate of the Smith-Morra. Neil Carr, in his book DEVELOPMENTS IN THE SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT, 1980 - 1989, blindly overlooks possible Black improve- ments in the opening - but that's nothing compared to his misjudgment of his "attack".

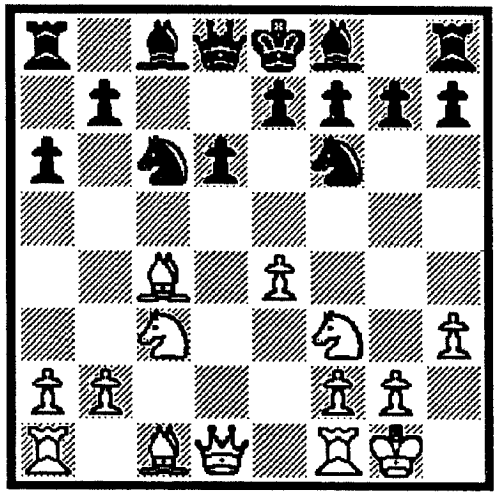
To create an objective analysis of the game, I checked and rechecked each critical variation - and then played them out against Zarkov. In this way I believe I have approached the truth of the game - a truth that has virtually nothing in common with Mr. Carr's annotations.

Carr Sachs
Lloyds Bank Masters
London 1984

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |
| **6. Bc4** | **a6** |
| **7. O-O** | **Nf6** |
| **8. h3** | |

( See the diagram on the next page)





Like Levy, I have to ask: "What kind of move is this?" I do not believe that there is any way a passive defensive move like 8.h3 or 8.a3 can justify the Gambit.

| | |
|---|---|
| **8...** | **e6** |
| **9. Qe2** | **Be7?!** |

Insufficiently sharp, and so White gets a chance. Black should play (as in the similar case after 8.a3) 9... b5! going into the Chicago Defense, where the inoffensive White rook pawn move appears simply as a loss of a tempo. In this way I believe Black would get a clear advantage out of the opening.

**10. Bf4?!**

White should have played 10.Rd1, threatening e5, with some compensation for the pawn. The actual text should just lose a vital tempo.

**10... Qa5?**

Misses an even simpler chance for clear advantage in the opening. Correct is 10... e5 11.Be3 O-O 12.Rfd1 and Black has transposed into Game 9, Wolff-Taylor, with the sole difference that White has the extra tempo h3. This doesn't have much significance

in the position, given that Black will develop his QB to e6. Black can continue as in the Wolff game with 12... b5 13.Bb3 Be6 -/+.

**11. a3 Ne5**

11... Qh5, intending to stir up trouble on the Kingside, looks sharper and stronger.

**12. Ne5 de5**

**13. Be3 b5**

Now this is necessary to make a square for the Q on b7.

**14. Bd3 O-O**

**15. b4 Qc7**

**16. Rac1 Qb7**

**17. f4 ef4**

**18. Bf4 Bd7**

**19. e5 Nd5**

**20. Nd5 ed5**

**21. Be3 g6**

Black's miscues have allowed White to develop some positional compensation for his pawn. Best for White now is 22.Bd4, with a strong blockade.

Instead Carr decides to toss material with wild abandon - and so the analytical duel begins.

**22. e6?!**

I say White is throwing away a second pawn for insufficient compensation - Carr gives the move two exclamation points.

**22... Be6**

**23. Bd4 Bd6**

**24. Bg6?**

I say this piece sacrifice is totally unsound. Carr gives the move two exclamation points.

**24... hg6**

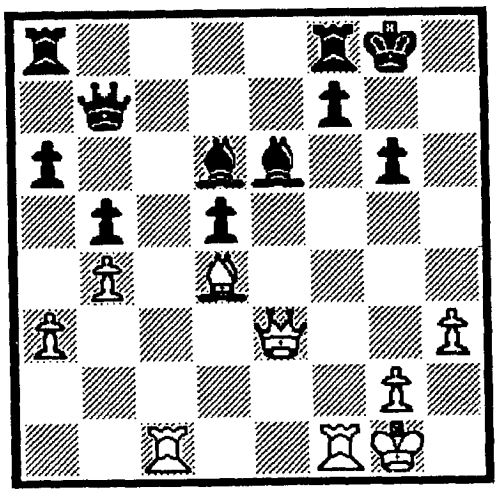
**25. Qe3**



I say White is lost - Carr gives himself another exclam' and implies that White has a winning attack.

Clearly there can only be one right judgment of this sharp position - and I don't think that answer is difficult to discover. Consider the diagram below: Black is a piece and a pawn up, his center is solid, and all his pieces except his QR are active. White has no direct threats, and it's Black's move.

The critical position



Black to move and win

**25... Kh7??**

OH NO NOT THIS! Carr, so generous with exclam's, fails to give this move a single question mark; likewise he fails to offer a single alternative to this horrid blunder, and thus suggests that Black had nothing better. But really folks, it's hard to find anything *worse* than this move! Black puts his K on a half open file, thus setting up mating threats for White while losing what amounts to two tempi (the misplaced K must soon run back to g8). Of course such a positional blunder and loss of time cannot go unpunished.

So what should Black play? Before I point out the winning move, I want to make it clear that White's "attack" is so

unimpressive that even second best play would give Black either a win (in most variations) or the sunny side of a probably drawn ending (after best play by White). The proof follows:

SIMPLE BUT SECOND BEST DEFENSE: 25... Rac8 (bringing that QR into play with exchanging threats) and now:

A. 26.Rcd1 Rc4 (threatening to eliminate the B, the mainspring of White's attack, while retaining a comfortable material advantage - thus if 27.Qh6 Rd4! wins at once for Black) 27.Ba1 (if 27.Bf6 Be7 28.Be5 Re4 wins) 27... Bc7 28.Qh6 Bb6+ 29.Kh1 d4 and wins.

B. 26.Qh6 f6 27.Qg6+ (27.Bf6 Qh7 wins) 27... Qg7 and it's all over.

C. 26.Rc8! (Best) Bc8 27.Bf6 (Again best: now Black must give back his piece, but he stays a pawn up) 27... Be7 28.Qe7 (Not 28.Bd4 f6 - +, and 28.Be7 Re8 29.Re1 Qd7! gives Black serious winning chances because of the pin and mobile passed pawn) 28... Qe7 29.Be7 Re8 30.Bf6 and White might be able to make a draw here, despite the minus pawn, because of the opposite colored bishops.

So we see that even after second best play by Black, White would have to play extremely accurately - and then he would be left struggling for a draw in a pawn down ending. Is this what Carr had in mind when he awarded himself five exclamation points over moves 22-25?

Still, White has not seen the worst. There is no need for Black to play only for a small endgame advantage when he can force the win!



THE BEST DEFENSE IS A COUNTERATTACK: 25... Rae8! Again the inactive QR comes into the fray but this time the WQ is the target! Black wins in all variations, as can be seen:

A. 26.Rf6 Bf5 27.Qh6 Be5 and Black wins, as once the WB is gone there is nothing left of the attack.

B. 26.Bf6 Be7 27.Bd4 Bd8 - + as Black controls the approaches to his K, e.g. 28.Qh6 f6 and there is no attack, so Black's extra piece will quickly decide.

C. 26.Qh6! (Best) f6 27.Rc6! (A clever resource found by Zarkov, and the only way to keep the game alive; if 27.Qg6+ Qg7 and White can resign) 27... Bg3! (the only winning move; horrible would be 27... Qc6?? 28.Qg6+ Kh8 29.Rf6 and *White* wins) 28.Qg6+ Qg7 29.Rf6 Rf6 30.Qe8+ Kh7! and now:

C1. 31.h4 (the only available waiting move - the answer proves that White can't wait!) 31... Qg4! and the dual threats of mate on d1 and taking on d4 are decisive.

C2. 31.Qd8 Rf8! slips out of the pin and wins.

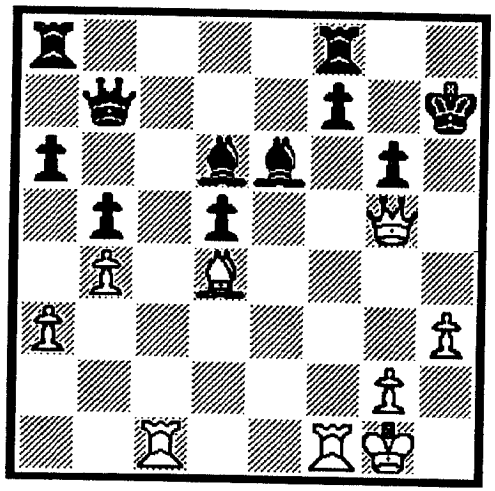
C3. 31.Bf6 Qf6 32.Qh5+ (Not 32.Re6? Qf2+ and mates) 32... Kg7 33.Qd1 (if 33.Rc1 d4 is good enough) 33... Qf2+ 34.Kh1 Bh3! and wins.

C4. 31.Re6 Re6! 32.Qh5+ Kg8 and Black is a rook ahead, for if White takes the Queen with 33.Bg7 then Re1 is mate, while 33.Qd5 Qd4+! also forces mate. This variation explains why the BKB had to go to g3, and not b8, on move 27. Once again, an attack against White's weak Kingside dark squares proves decisive!

C5. 31.Ra6 (Best) Qc7! (threatens to mate with either Qc1 or Bh2 and Rf1) 32.Qh5+ Rh6 33.Qd1 Qf4. Black has beaten off White's attack and should now win with his extra piece.

I believe these variations clearly demonstrate the failure of White's sacrifices, and of the annotations that extol them. Black can easily reach a somewhat better ending; or he can force the win with sharp and accurate play.

**26. Qg5**



White has a winning attack

What a difference one move makes! Because of Black's "helpmate style" 25... Kh7, White now threatens mate in two; and positionally speaking, Black is playing without his QR.

I can see no defense for Black in *this* position.

26... Be7

Or 26... f6 27.Qh4+ Kg8 (note the double loss of tempo) 28.Rf6 and wins.

**27. Rf6!**



Nails down the dark square weaknesses. Black can't take: 27... Bf6 28.Qf6 Rg8 29.Qh4 mate.

**27... Rh8**

This move loses by force - need I add that Carr decorates it with an exclamation point?

**28. Rcf1 Kg8**

Makes it easy, but even on the more complicated 28... Bf8 White can win as follows: 29.Rg6! fg6 30.Rf8! Rhf8 (Best) 31.Qh4+ Kg8 32.Qh8+ Kf7 33.Qg7+ Ke8 34.Qb7 Rc8 35.Bc5 and the attacking power of the Queen, accentuated by the opposite colored bishops, is decisive.

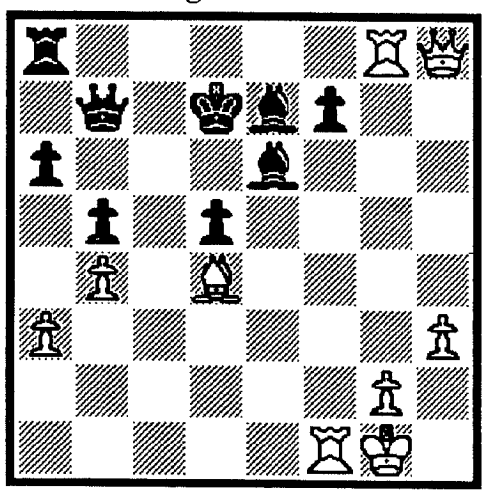
**29. Rg6+ Kf8**

**30. Qe5 Ke8**

Throws away the exchange, but 30... Rh7 31.Re6 was also pretty grim.

**31. Qh8+ Kd7**

**32. Rg8**



White has consolidated his advantage of the exchange - the rest is easy.

| | |
|---|---|
| **32...** | **Rg8** |
| **33. Qg8** | **Qc7** |
| **34. Qg7** | **Qd6** |
| **35. Qe5** | **Qc6** |
| **36. Qe3** | **Bd6** |
| **37. Rc1** | **Qb7** |
| **38. Qc3** | **Bc7** |
| **39. h4** | **Bf4** |
| **40. Rf1** | **Qb8** |
| **41. h5** | **Bg4** |
| **42. Qc5** | **Bd6** |
| **43. Qa7+** | **Resigns** |

There is no point in playing on for if 43... Qa7 44.Rf7+ wins.

Opening Conclusions, Part III: Of the various eighth move alternatives, only Qe2 is a real improvement on 8.Bg5. Other moves give Black (assuming he plays aggressively) a clear advantage out of the opening. By playing 8.Qe2 and following with extremely accurate play (see note to move 11, Game 7) White can keep his disadvantage to a minimum. However, even in this line only Black has winning chances. Also bear in mind that White has a rigid line of play here; improvements for Black are possible.



## PART IV
## NEW IDEAS IN THE SMITH-MORRA

The following game is the only published example that I know of a new and completely different way of playing the Smith-Morra. White seeks compensation for his pawn not in development or attack, but rather in pawn structure: very early on he inflicts doubled pawns on Black, albeit at the cost of the two bishops. This new idea proves successful in this game - but Black cooperates in his demise by playing on both wings while forgetting to tend his lonely King that remains stranded in the center.

To find out how to correctly play the Black position I had to go back to the Bronstein - Botvinnik match of 1951: clearly one must be ready for anything when facing the Smith-Morra!

In my notes I will also point out a different untried attack for White - and its possible antidote - that I discovered while doing the analysis for this book.

The opening analysis for this last game cannot be definitive - too much is unknown. These new lines - and others still undiscovered - may prove to be the future battleground of the Smith-Morra.

### GAME 12: WHITE TRIES 7.Bg5 AND 8.Bf6

Stewart Harman

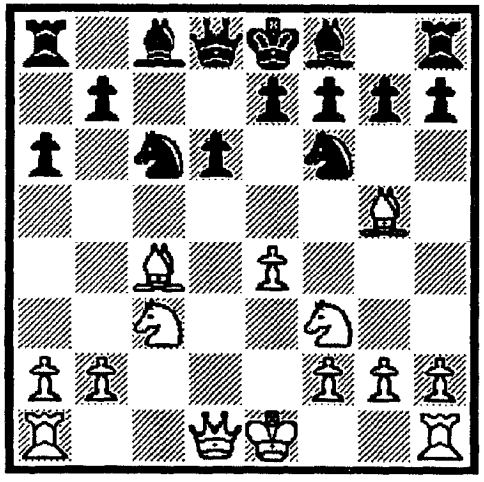
Correspondence 1980

| | |
|---|---|
| **1. e4** | **c5** |
| **2. d4** | **cd4** |
| **3. c3** | **dc3** |
| **4. Nc3** | **Nc6** |
| **5. Nf3** | **d6** |

**6. Bc4 a6**
**7. Bg5**

The start of White's new plan - as I pointed out in the notes to Rizzitano - Taylor, Game 5, Black must allow the following exchange, for if 7... h6? 8.Qb3! is good for White.

**7... Nf6**



Rizzitano played 8.O-O here, transposing into the 8.Bg5 line that we have seen is good for Black. This game features a new plan with 8.Bf6 - and then there is still another move!

A question that I have asked myself is: What if White tries 8.e5 here? This move does nothing in the move order 7.O-O Nf6 8.e5 (see note to move 8, Game 7) but here there is an important difference: White can still castle Queenside. We can see this point in the variation 8.e5!? de5 9.Qd8+ Nd8 10.Ne5 e6 11.O-O-O. Certainly White is more active here than in the Gooris - Schmidt game referred to above, but does he have enough for the pawn? I think it's possible.

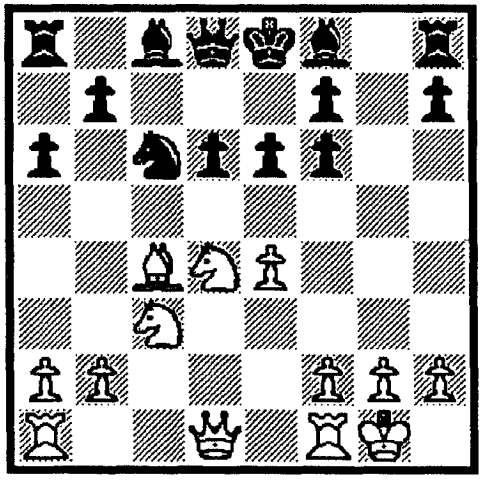


However, Black does not have to play this way, for on the 9th move he can vary with 9... Kd8!?. This move in turn tries to take advantage of the small differences in position created by White's replacing of O-O with Bg5. In the Gooris - Schmidt game, the analogous K recapture would be bad because of 10.Ng5 - but here White doesn't have that square. If White plays 10.Bf7 then 10... e6 ties up the WKB and appears to force an eventual exchange on f6, reuniting Black's pawns. This line looks good for Black - but one must remember that these variations are all uncharted territory.

**8. Bf6 gf6**

Weaker is 8... ef6 in view of 9.Qb3.

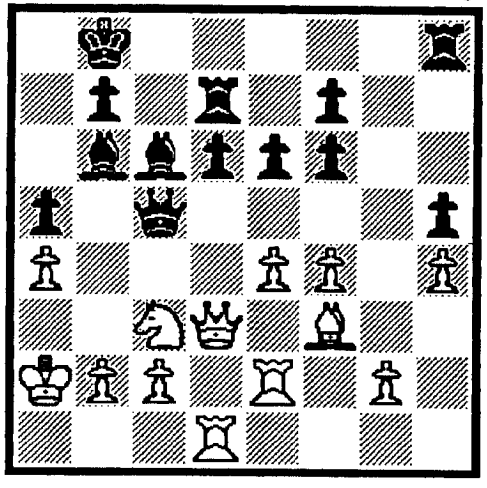
**9. O-O e6**
**10. Nd4**



A highly interesting position has appeared, which looks absolutely nothing like the main lines of the Smith-Morra. Indeed, to find an analogous structure one must go to (in the main line Sicilian with 2.Nf3 and 3.d4) the Botvinnik variation of the Rauser Attack! This somewhat obscure variation produces a nearly identical pawn array for both Black and White, with two exceptions: in the Botvinnik line the Black h pawn is at h6, not h7, and also White has a

pawn on c2, which here is off the board. Naturally to understand how to play this type of position we must go to the former World Champion himself.

Bronstein - Botvinnik, Game 6, World Championship Match 1951: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 cd4 4.Nd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 d6 6.Bg5 e6 7.Qd2 h6 8.Bf6 gf6 9.O-O-O a6 10.f4 Bd7 11.Kb1 Be7 12.Be2 Nd4 13.Qd4 Qa5 14.Rhf1 h5 15.Rf3 Qc5 16.Qd2 Bc6 17.Re3 Qa5 18.Bf3 O-O-O 19.Qd3 Rd7 20.h4 Kb8 21.a3 Bd8 22.Ka2 Qc5 23.Re2 a5 24.a4 Bb6 and we have reached the diagram below.



Botvinnik has now fully equalized the game, and indeed he went on to win a remarkable ending. The student should note the early development of the Black Bishops, the probing moves with the Q, the carefully prepared castling, and finally the intricate maneuvering ending in the creation of a Q and KB battery, accentuating Black's superiority on the dark squares.

With this example before us, it's easy to see that Harman's next two moves (and in fact his whole plan through move 17) are faulty. The first inaccuracy (10... Nd4) develops the WQ before



Black is ready to oppose it; the second (11... b5) cuts out the possibility of Queenside castling.

Note that in this Smith-Morra game (with the Black h pawn on h7), castling Kingside is possible. Black's impetuous advance of the h pawn (moves 16-17) has the same effect as the premature 11... b5, in that it cuts out castling on the affected side of the board.

In short, Harman weakens both wings, and so his K, stuck in the center, never has any security.

10... Nd4?!

Better is 10... Bd7, when Botvinnik style maneuvers may well equalize the positional factors - which in this case would give Black a clear advantage because of his extra pawn.

**11. Qd4 b5?!**

Better is 11... Be7 with the idea of ... Qa5-c5.

**12. Bb3 Rb8**
**13. Kh1 Be7**
**14. f4 Qb6**
**15. Qd3 Bd7**
**16. Rfe1 h5?**

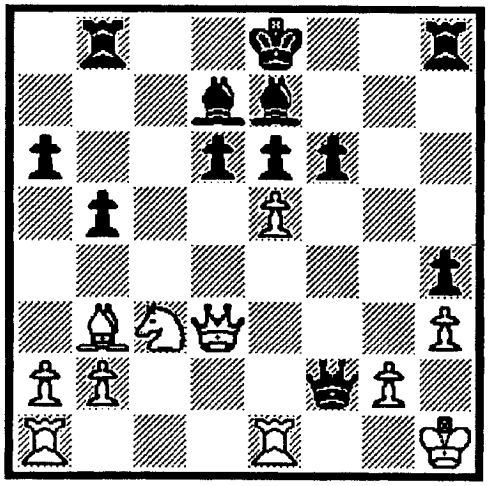
Burning his bridges: now Black can never castle on either side. The move also weakens the g6 square. Much better would be 16... a5, continuing his Queenside play, which might distract White from assaulting the BK.

**17. f5 h4**

This move and the next, which continue his bad plan (Black certainly has no Kingside attack) just give White tempi for his assault.

**18. h3 Qf2**
**19. fe6 fe6**

**20. e5!**



An excellent clearance sacrifice: now White has e4 for the N and an open diagonal to g6 (note how the advance of the Black h pawn hurts).

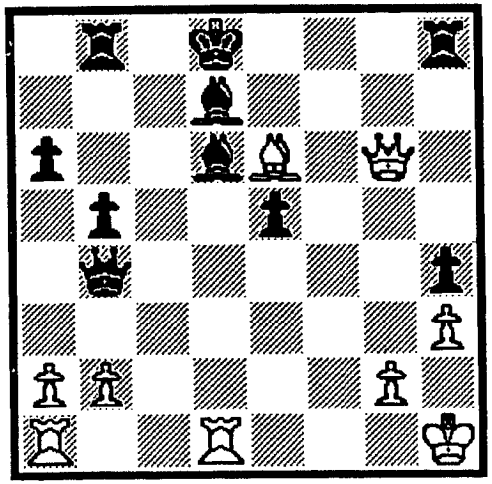
| | |
|---|---|
| **20...** | **fe5** |
| **21. Ne4** | **Qd4** |
| **22. Nd6+!!** | |

In true Spielmann style White continues with a King hunt sacrifice!

| | |
|---|---|
| **22...** | **Bd6** |
| **23. Qg6+** | **Kd8** |
| **24. Red1** | **Qb4** |
| **25. Be6** | |

( See the diagram on the next page)





The effects of White's sacrifices can clearly be seen: Black's King protecting pawns are gone, and the open files beckon the White Rooks. The precipitously advanced wing pawns have left no safe haven for the BK.

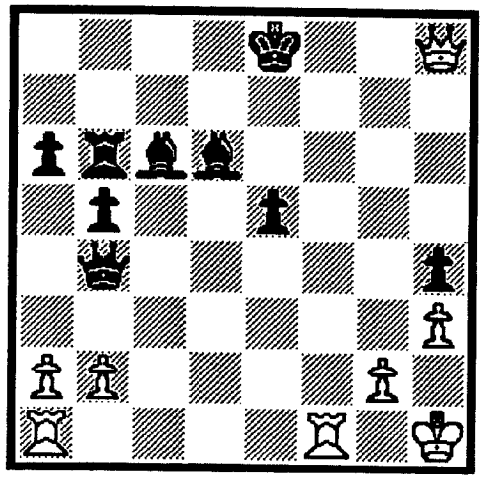
It's not surprising that White forces the win in a few moves.

| | |
|---|---|
| **25...** | **Re8** |
| **26. Bf7** | **Rb6** |
| **27. Be8** | **Be8** |
| **28. Qe6** | **Bd7** |
| **29. Qf6+** | **Ke8** |

If 29... Kc7 30.Rac1+ Rc6 31.a3 wins.

| | |
|---|---|
| **30. Rf1** | **Bc6** |
| **31. Qh8+!** | |

( See the diagram on the next page)



This check forces the win against all three of Black's defenses, as can be seen:

A. 31... Bf8 32.Rf2 and there is no way to stop 33.Raf1, winning the pinned bishop.

B. 31... Kd7 32.Rf7+ Be7 (32... Ke6 33.Qf6+ Kd5 34.Rd1+ Kc4 35.Qf1+! and White mates or wins the Queen) 33.Rd1+ Bd5 (33... Ke6 34.Qg8! puts the BK in a mating crossfire) 34.Qe5 (Simplest) 34... Ke8 35.Qd5 Rd6 36.Qh5! Rd1+ 37.Rf1+ Kd7 38.Rd1+ and White has the exchange, a pawn, and an attack: good enough!

C. 31... Ke7 (the toughest defense, but still no problem when White plays accurately) 32.Qg7+ and now:

C1. 32... Ke8 33.Rad1! (threatens 34.Qg8 or Qg6+) 33... Rb7 (33... Bd7 34.Rf8+! Bf8 35.Qd7 Mate) 34.Qg6+ Kd7 35.Rd6+! Qd6 36.Rf7+ wins the Queen.



C2. 32... Kd8 33.Rad1! (threatens 34.Rf8+) 33... Be8 (33... Bd7 34.Rf8+! Kc7 35.Rf7 wins; 33... Kc8 34.Rf7 wins) 34.Rf8 (threatens 35.Qf7) 34... Qc4 35.Qg6 Qc6 36.Rd6+! Qd6 37.Qe8+ Kc7 38.Qc8 Mate!

Black, not wishing to see all those bloodstained postcards, found a better choice.

**Resigns**

Opening Conclusions, Part IV: It's too early for definitive conclusions on these new ideas - but it seems to me that if Botvinnik can equalize this type of position with even material, then when Black is a pawn up he should be able to get the advantage.

## A FEW GENERAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THOSE WHO FIGHT THE SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT

1. Seize every opportunity to play aggressively with Black. If you can take over the initiative in the opening, or attack the White King, this in combination with the extra pawn will nearly always be decisive. Conversely, if you play passively, White will nearly always generate compensation for the pawn.

2. Don't play your Q to c7 - this is virtually *always* a horrible square!

3. Remember that the 6... a6 line is a fluid variation with many transpositional possibilities. Be ready, according to circumstance, to play a Chicago Defense, a Botvinnik variation, or a no holds barred Kingside attack.

4. Be aware that even as you read this, Smith-Morra Gambit devotees are feverishly seeking improvements for White. Expect the unexpected - and if someone slams down a new move against you, don't let "novelty shock" drive you on to the defensive. The best defense is a counterattack!



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